

Police to hold weekly public grievance meets across all stations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Common citizens need not run from pillar to post to seek redressal for their grievances with the Delhi Police, the department is organising a weekly 'Thana Divas-Jan Sunwai' at every police station across the national capital, starting next week. Matters do not end there, as senior police officials will be held accountable for follow-up actions.

This order, issued by Police Commissioner Satish Golcha, after Delhi Lt Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu's directions, to significantly augment public outreach,

enhance accessibility of police services, and ensure the prompt redressal of public grievances.

The circular said that the SHOs, ACPs and district DCPs would be personally responsible for implementation, warning that any delay, negligence or casual handling of grievances would be viewed seriously.

The disposal of grievances received during Jan Sunwai shall be monitored closely at all supervisory levels. Particular emphasis shall be laid on quality, timeliness, and effectiveness of redressal. Any undue delay, negligence, or casual handling of grievances shall be viewed

adversely, the comprehensive order said.

The Jan Sunwai session will be held every Saturday from 10.00 am to 2.00 pm, and all complaints brought during it will be heard irrespective of whether they are registered on the Integrated Complaint Monitoring System (ICMS). Complaints received during the hearings will subsequently be uploaded on the portal, the circular said.

"Senior officers from the ranks of Special Commissioner of Police, Joint Commissioner of Police, Additional Commissioner of Police, Deputy Commissioner of Police and Assistant Commissioner of Police will attend the public



hearings on a rotational basis to ensure prompt redressal of grievances and strengthen public confidence in the police complaint mechanism," the order said.

"Any complainant who comes in Jan Sunwai shall be

heard, irrespective of facts that his/her complaint is registered on ICMS or not.

Complaints received during the Jan Sunwai shall be accepted and subsequently uploaded on ICMS. SHOs shall ensure proper seating

arrangements, assistance desks, and a citizen-friendly environment during the conduct of Thana Divas-Jan Sunwai," the order said.

Police stations have been directed to maintain separate records of grievances received during the sessions, while complaints requiring inquiry or field verification must be acted upon immediately and disposed of within a reasonable timeframe.

"District DCPs have been asked to publicise the initiative through police station notice boards, social media platforms, Resident Welfare Associations, Market Welfare Associations and beat staff to maximise public participa-

tion," the officer added.

The guidelines issued after the Lt Governor's meeting with CP, Delhi, and other senior officials will ensure structured public grievance redressal, enhanced police-public interface, and improved accountability at all levels. It will involve creating an open platform to address complaints, receive suggestions, and handle local public safety issues quickly on the ground.

The circular said it may be noted the LG has been emphasising public-centric, accessible, and interactive policing as the most effective way to address public grievances and strengthen com-

munity confidence in law enforcement right since the time he took over.

"A fortnightly report regarding conduct of Thana Divas-Jan Sunwai, number of grievances received, disposed of, and pending, along with significant issues identified, shall be submitted by each District to Vigilance Division and concerned Addl. CP/Jt. CP Range on every Monday as per the prescribed format. All District DCSP shall circulate these instructions down to the level of Police Stations and ensure meticulous compliance. Non-compliance of these instructions shall be viewed seriously and adversely," it said.

DFS deputy chief sheds light on Delhi's growing fire hazard

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

Fatal fire incidents in a Malviya Nagar hotel and a Govindpuri residential building have again drawn attention to fire safety lapses, unregulated construction and chronic resource shortages in the national capital. The two incidents, which claimed multiple lives within days of each other, occurred during what the Delhi Fire Service (DFS) describes as the busiest and most dangerous period of the year for fire-related emergencies.

According to DFS Deputy Chief Fire Officer AK Malik, the overwhelming majority of fatal fires occur in buildings that never undergo fire safety scrutiny.

"Buildings with fire safety certificates account for only 1 per cent of total fire accidents. Accidents mostly occur in establishments that are neither referred to DFS nor issued a fire NOC," Malik said.

Referring to the Malviya



DFS Deputy Chief Fire Officer AK Malik

Nagar hotel blaze, in which 22 people died, and dozens were rescued, Malik said the establishment had never been referred to the fire department by the concerned building authority. Cities forward their maps to the DFS, which issues fire safety directives. Once construction is complete, we inspect the premises and issue a fire safety certificate if all applicable norms are met. Incidentally, Flourish Inn had never been referred to the DFS by the building authority," he said.

Malik said investigators

found serious design flaws in the hotel building. He said there was no ventilation, and even the bathroom windows were permanently sealed. The building behaved like a shaft, allowing smoke and heat to travel rapidly, he added, noting that DFS personnel rescued 38 people while conducting firefighting and search operations.

The comments gain significance in light of the Govindpuri house fire, where three family members died after being trapped inside a residential building. Malik noted that mixed-use struc-

tures, where commercial activity operates on lower floors and families reside above, are particularly vulnerable to fires.

He also pointed to changing urban architecture as a growing risk factor. Malik said Delhi homes have changed: earlier houses had better ventilation and higher ceilings, while today interiors contain highly flammable materials, causing fires to spread much faster.

To address the issue, DFS has proposed making sprinklers and smoke detectors mandatory in new buildings and is seeking government support to encourage their installation in existing structures. Malik claimed such measures could reduce fire fatalities by as much as 97 per cent.

Rising call volumes compound the challenge during the summer. Malik said DFS easily receives around 200 calls a day during this period. He added that electricity usage is at an all-time high due to Delhi's extreme heat

and that fire incidents increase sharply from summer through the festive season.

Despite the growing burden, DFS is grappling with a severe workforce crunch. Malik said the department is short 9,223 operational personnel and that it is difficult to manage the volume of fire accidents this quarter because of the shortage.

The officer said the department has submitted proposals to the government seeking additional workforce, modern equipment and new technologies. Plans are also underway to establish eight new fire stations annually and digitise response systems to improve emergency mobilisation.

As Delhi witnesses a succession of deadly fires, the recent tragedies in Malviya Nagar and Govindpuri highlighted the same pattern: unsafe buildings, inadequate preventive measures and a fire service struggling to keep pace with the city's rapid and often unregulated growth.

Mercury to climb in Delhi this week

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

After several days of relatively mild June weather, Delhi is set to witness a gradual rise in temperatures over the coming week, though intermittent thunderstorms and light rain are expected to provide brief relief from the heat.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), the maximum temperatures across the national capital are likely to increase by 4-6 degrees Celsius over the next seven days, while the minimum temperatures may rise by 3-5 degrees Celsius, signalling a return to hotter conditions as the city inches closer to the monsoon season.

The national capital recorded a maximum temperature of 38.5 degrees Celsius on Sunday, 1.4 notches below seasonal average, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The weather department has forecast very light to light



rainfall accompanied by gusts and thunderstorms on Monday afternoon and evening. The maximum and minimum temperatures are likely to settle around 39 and 26 degrees Celsius, respectively. On Sunday, the maximum temperatures logged across Delhi's key weather stations ranged between 38.4 and 39.1 degrees Celsius.

Ridge was the hottest at 39.1 degrees Celsius, 1.2 degrees above normal, followed by Lodi Road at 38.7 degrees Celsius and Palam at 38.6 degrees Celsius.

Safdarjung, the city's base station, recorded a maximum

of 38.5 degrees Celsius, while Ayanagar registered 38.4 degrees Celsius, 3.1 degrees below normal.

The minimum ranged between 23.4 degrees Celsius and 26.2 degrees Celsius.

Safdarjung recorded the highest minimum temperature at 26.2 degrees Celsius, 1.8 degrees below normal, followed by Palam at 25.6 degrees Celsius and Ayanagar at 24.8 degrees Celsius.

Lodi Road recorded a minimum of 24.6 degrees Celsius, while Ridge was the coolest at 23.4 degrees Celsius, 3.2 degrees below normal, IMD data showed.

Police constable poses as customer to bust sex racket in Paharganj

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A constable from Delhi Police's Central District walked into a spa on DBG Road in Paharganj on Saturday evening, posing as an ordinary customer. He paid ₹1,800 in pre-recorded currency notes to the operator, was introduced to one of the women working there for services, and then gave a signal that brought his waiting team crashing through the door. Within minutes, an organised prostitution racket that had been running under the cover of a salon and spa was exposed, one man was arrested, and five women were rescued from the premises.

DCP Central District Rohit Rajbir Singh confirmed the operation followed specific intelligence received a day earlier. "Secret information was received regarding immoral trafficking activities being carried out under the guise of a spa in Paharganj. A decoy customer operation was planned and executed to verify the allegations and take legal action," Singh said.

The information that reached Paharganj police station on June 13 indicated that customers visiting the



spa were being lured and offered services in exchange for money, with the spa functioning as a front for the actual business being conducted on the premises.

A dedicated raiding team was constituted, and a constable dressed in plain clothes was briefed and sent in as the decoy customer. Inside, the constable made contact with the spa staff and was offered services in exchange for payment. He handed over the pre-recorded currency notes amounting to ₹1,800 to the spa operator and was introduced to one of the women present for the provision of services. At that point, Lalit gave the predetermined signal to the team waiting outside.

The raiding team entered the premises immediately. The raid confirmed the illegal activities being carried out from the spa, and evidence was seized on the spot. A case was registered under

Sections 3, 4, and 5 of the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act as FIR No. 274/2026 at the Paharganj police station.

The man arrested has been identified as Saved Ali alias Shabir, 29, a resident of Rampur in Uttar Pradesh, who was operating and managing the salon and spa. He has no previous criminal record. During questioning, it was established that he was the one managing and facilitating the activities on the premises, coordinating between customers and the women working there.

Five women, aged between 20 and 40 years, were found present at the spa and have been rescued. Police recovered ₹4,200 in cash, including the ₹1,800 in pre-recorded decoy money used in the operation, along with a customer entry register and other material indicating an organised commercial operation rather than an isolated incident.

Delhi zoo invites citizens for weekly bird-monitoring, biodiversity drives

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi zoo on Sunday launched a citizen science initiative to encourage public participation in bird monitoring and biodiversity conservation through weekly bird-watching sessions within its premises.

The inaugural edition of the 'Sunday Bird Walk - National Zoological Park' was held from 6.30 am to 9.30 am under the guidance of ornithologist Dr Paritosh Ahmad and a team of birding volunteers, according to a statement.

Of the 58 registered applicants, 23 people, including birdwatchers, students, nature enthusiasts and wildlife lovers, took part in the walk. The zoo's director and other officials also took part.

The participants documented 33 bird species and recorded sightings of more than 100 individual birds across different parts of the zoo, the National Zoological Park (NZP), also known as the Delhi Zoo, said in the statement.

It said the initiative has been designed as a citizen science platform to help document avian diversity while familiarising partici-



pants with scientific methods of bird observation, identification and data recording.

Species recorded during the walk included Indian Peafowl, Yellow-footed Green Pigeon, Asian Koel, Painted Stork, Indian Cormorant, Black-crowned Night Heron, White-throated Kingfisher, Brown-headed Barbet, and Rose-ringed Parakeet, among others.

Addressing the participants, Ahmad spoke about bird identification, behaviour and ecological significance. He highlighted the role of birds in maintaining ecological balance through activities such as seed dispersal, pollination, pest control and ecosystem monitoring.

The event concluded with an interactive discussion session and a group photo-

graph involving participants, experts and zoo officials, according to the statement.

Officials said the bird walk will now be organised every Sunday morning, with participation limited to 20 individuals per session.

The programme is open to people aged 18 years and above, and registrations will be accepted on a first-come, first-served basis through the zoo's official website and the NZP Sathi mobile application, it added.

Selected participants will be required to report at the zoo entrance by 6.15 am, while the bird-watching session will take place from 6.30 am to 9.30 am.

The official said the initiative is expected to help generate biodiversity records while promoting awareness about conservation among the public.

MCOCA slapped on gang leader posing as crime branch officer

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A man who dropped out of school in the 4th standard and built a criminal career by impersonating Crime Branch police officers to rob and cheat people across India. The man has had the stringent Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA) invoked against him by Delhi's Central District Police, less than two years after he walked out of judicial custody in a previous MCOCA case in Mumbai and went straight back to crime.

The accused, Nasir Hafiz Khan, also known as Irani and Sameer, is a resident of Bhogal in Delhi, originally from Ambiwali in Mumbai. He has 38 criminal cases against him across Delhi, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, and Haryana.

DCP Central District Rohit Rajbir Singh confirmed the action. "Approval under Section 23(1)(a) MCOCA was granted by senior officers after detailed scrutiny of evidence, following which a fresh FIR under Section 3 MCOCA was registered against the organised crime syndicate," Singh said.

The trick at the heart of Khan's operation is the part that should worry ordinary citizens most. He and his associates would impersonate Crime Branch police officers to gain the trust of victims before robbing or cheating them. The badge, the manner, and the authority that people instinctively defer to — all of it was a costume.

The case that brought him to Delhi Police's attention this time was registered as FIR No. 389/2025 at the DBG Road police station, involving a robbery of ₹18.84 lakh committed on October 23, 2025. That robbery happened barely two months after Khan had been released from judicial custody in a prior MCOCA case registered by Mumbai Police, where he had remained jailed until August 2024.

After the Delhi robbery,



Khan went on the run, and the trail he left behind reads like a tour of India's crime map. He fled from Mumbai to Nagpur, where he was booked in two separate cheating cases within days of each other in November 2025, one involving the theft of jewellery weighing approximately 75 grams and the other a gold chain of approximately 10 tolas. From Nagpur, he moved to Ajmer in Rajasthan, where he allegedly cheated a senior citizen woman of gold jewellery worth approximately Rs 40 lakh in December 2025. Police finally caught up with him on January 3, 2026, after what the department described as painstaking work involving scrutiny of thousands of CCTV footage clips, sustained technical surveillance, and meticulous fieldwork by the police team. At his instance, police recovered five mobile phones, internet dongles, the car he had been paying off using money from the robbery, the bag used in the crime, and other incriminating documents.

What made Khan eligible for MCOCA, a law typically associated with mafia-style organised crime, was the pattern investigators uncovered. He had been charged with multiple cognisable offences carrying sentences of three years or more, with courts taking cognisance in 16 of his cases registered in Delhi alone.

Despite ongoing prosecutions, he continued to commit robberies, including cases registered at the DBG Road and Prasad Nagar police stations, thereby fulfilling the legal definition of continuing unlawful activity required to invoke the Act.

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Police arrest proclaimed offender in Ghaziabad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A man who was declared a proclaimed offender earlier this month for repeatedly attacking his wife with a knife, holding her responsible for the deaths of their two newborn children, was arrested by the Delhi Police's Crime Branch in Ghaziabad on Saturday. He was traced to a hideout while allegedly plotting another assault on her.

The accused, Sajid Ali, a resident of Bindapur, had been on the run since 2025 to avoid arrest. He was declared a proclaimed offender in an attempt-to-murder case registered at the Dabri police station in



2021. He was also wanted in a separate case involving grievous hurt and had been evading trial in another criminal case.

A senior police officer described the pattern behind Sajid's attacks on his wife. "Sajid had allegedly attacked his wife multiple

times with the intention of killing her. Investigators described him as a maniac and a jilted husband, citing his alleged obsessive hostility towards his wife, whom he blamed for the deaths of their two children shortly after birth," the officer said. Police said Sajid married

in 2015. The couple lost two children, both of whom died shortly after birth. According to police, these losses deeply affected Sajid, and he gradually developed resentment toward his wife, holding her responsible for the deaths. He subsequently became addicted to drugs and alcohol and began frequently demanding money from her to sustain his addiction.

In 2021, Sajid allegedly attacked his wife with a knife on three separate occasions, which led to his arrest in the attempted murder case. He was released from jail in November 2024. Within months, in 2025, he allegedly attacked her again and

then went into hiding to evade arrest.

A team from the Crime Branch worked to track him down and traced his location to the Ikram Nagar area in Ghaziabad. Acting on this information, the team laid a trap near Labour Chowk on Saturday. Sajid was spotted arriving to meet an associate. When he noticed the police team, he attempted to flee but was apprehended after a brief chase.

At the time of his arrest, Sajid had already been declared a proclaimed offender by a local court in the 2021 attempt-to-murder case, and non-bailable warrants had been issued against him in another case as well.

Four arrested for allegedly setting off fatal Govindpuri fire

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police have apprehended a 17-year-old minor girl and arrested three adults for their alleged role in a deliberate arson attack that killed three members of a family and injured eight others in Tughlakabad Extension, Govindpuri, Southeast Delhi.

The fire broke out at around 2:24 am on Friday, June 12, in building No. RZ-171/1 under the Govindpuri police station limits. What was initially suspected to be an accidental blaze caused by a short circuit was later

confirmed as planned arson stemming from a personal and monetary dispute.

The deceased have been identified as 28-year-old Pankaj (also known as Kuku), the family's sole breadwinner who had lost his father to cancer two years ago; his 20-year-old sister Soni (or Sonia); and their 70-year-old maternal grandmother Sushila Devi. All three lived on the third floor. Pankaj's mother, 50-year-old Guddi Devi (who is speech-impaired), and his 18-year-old sister Moni (or Mani) are critically injured and under treatment at Safdarjung Hospital and AIIMS Trauma Centre. Eight

people in total were injured in the blaze.

According to police, the minor girl from Navjeevan Camp in Govindpuri entered the building's ground-floor parking area minutes before the fire, poured petrol on a scooter belonging to Deepak, a fifth-floor resident, and set it ablaze using a matchbox. CCTV footage captured a woman, later identified as the minor with her face partially covered, entering and exiting the premises shortly before the incident. The flames then spread rapidly, engulfing multiple floors and trapping residents.

During questioning, the



minor disclosed that she was instigated and provided petrol and a matchbox by 27-year-old Sarita from Girinagar in Govindpuri.

Further probing revealed

that Sarita acted on the instructions of brothers Niranjan (33) and Rajkumar (27), both residents of Navjeevan Camp, who allegedly hatched the conspir-

acy to settle a personal and financial score with Deepak. An FIR was initially registered at the Govindpuri police station for fire-related negligence. On Sunday, Delhi Police added charges of criminal conspiracy, culpable homicide, attempt to commit culpable homicide, mischief by fire, and lurking house-trespass by night under sections of Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). All four accused, the minor girl, Sarita, Niranjan, and Rajkumar, have been apprehended.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (DCP), Southeast district, Hemant Tiwari, stated that the minor confessed to

acting at Sarita's behest to target Deepak's scooter over the monetary dispute. "She told us that Sarita had instigated her, providing petrol and a matchbox to set ablaze the scooter of one Deepak, over a monetary dispute," Tiwari said. The fire's rapid spread and the building's iron grills and locked terrace hampered rescue efforts, though locals formed human chains and fire services evacuated trapped residents.

The case highlights concerns about the involvement of a minor in a serious crime and the use of juveniles in disputes, said a police official involved in the probe.

Police are continuing the investigation to determine whether more people were involved and to reconstruct the sequence of events fully. The accused are being questioned, and further arrests or charges cannot be ruled out.

The incident has left the local community in shock, with residents demanding stricter action against those responsible for endangering innocent lives over a personal vendetta. The three deceased were laid to rest amid mourning, while the injured remain under medical care. Further updates are expected as the probe progresses.

CM Rekha leads mega cleanliness drive across 28 Yamuna ghats

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday led a mega cleaning drive conducted simultaneously across 28 ghats and riverbank locations spanning nearly 22 kilometres of the Yamuna riverfront.

The CM participated in shramdaan at Geeta Colony Ghat alongside thousands of volunteers from over 500 social and religious organisations and administered a collective cleanliness pledge to citizens present at the drive.

The Chief Minister said the Yamuna is not merely a river but a source of faith, culture, and life for crores of people and that the purpose of worship cannot be fulfilled if people continue polluting it. "Yamuna is the life-line of Delhi and is like a mother to all of us. Now, all of us have to dedicate 365 days towards keeping it clean," she said.

She appealed to citizens not to throw waste, plastic, religious offerings, flowers, garlands, idols, or other materials into the river,



noting that large quantities of broken idols, garments used for deities, and worship materials wrapped in plastic had been removed during the drive, pointing to the need for behavioural change among the public.

The pledge administered to volunteers covered not immersing worship materials or idols in the river, avoiding single-use plastics, not dumping waste or old clothes, keeping riverbanks clean, and spreading awareness among others.

The Chief Minister said the campaign would not be a one-time event and that the Delhi Government



would continue organising similar drives regularly at various locations.

She added that projects worth over ₹1,000 crore have been approved for Yamuna rejuvenation, including 12 new decentralised sewage treatment plants under the AMRUT scheme in the Najafgarh area at a cost of ₹860 crore, to prevent untreated sewage from entering the Najafgarh Drain and the Yamuna, along with upgradation of the Keshopur STP and rainwater harvesting initiatives.

Delhi BJP President Harsh Malhotra, who carried out shramdaan near Yamuna

Bank Metro Station along with South Delhi BJP President Maya Singh Bisht and MLAs Kartar Singh Tanwar and Chandan Chaudhary, cleaned approximately 500 yards of the ghat area.

Malhotra said Yamuna pollution has remained a major challenge for years, but concrete, result-oriented steps are now being taken under coordinated Central and Delhi government efforts. He said the focus is on increasing sewage treatment capacity, stopping polluted drain water, waste management, and public participation.



"Clean Yamuna, Healthy Delhi, and a Better Future, this is our goal and commitment," he said, comparing the effort to the Namami Gange campaign for the Ganga.

Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta also participated near the Old Yamuna Bridge with MLA Sanjay Goyal and former Mayor Raja Iqbal Singh. Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh led cleaning at ITO Hathi Ghat, saying awareness about Yamuna cleanliness is continuously increasing among people.

Former BJP chief and MP Manoj Tiwari led the drive at Sur Ghat, Wazirabad, saying

the commitment has continued since 2014. MP Yogendra Chandolia, at Nigambodh Yamuna Bazaar, said the previous Kejriwal government only made announcements for years, while work is now progressing in a time-bound manner.

MP Kamaljeet Sehrawat participated in Wazirabad Yamuna Ghat. MP Ramvir Singh Bidhuri cleaned around 500 metres near Sarai Kale Khan and administered the cleanliness pledge to hundreds of workers. MP Praveen Khandelwal, who cleaned around one truckload of garbage at Vasudev Ghat, announced a dedicated space at Agrasen Park, Kashmiri Gate, for collecting broken idols instead of immersing them.

Rajya Sabha MP Swati Maliwal, who worked at Kalindi Kunj, said in 15 years of politics, this was the first time she had participated in such a Yamuna campaign organised by a political party, adding that no such detailed effort was made during 12 years of the previous Delhi Government.

Yamuna Task Force starts rejuvenation work

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The newly created Yamuna Task Force, comprising officers and personnel of the Territorial Army, has started patrolling and performing other work under its mandate as part of the rejuvenation of the river in Delhi. The task force took part in the mega Yamuna riverbank cleanliness campaign led by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday.

"The Indian Army and the Government of India's Ministry of Defence decided to form the Yamuna Task Force here...The Indian Army's involvement in this brings with it people's expectations and hopes, and we will always live up to them," Anurag Singh, lieutenant colonel, officer commanding, Yamuna Task Force, said.

Singh said that the Yamuna Task Force was raised in March as part of the 137 composite ecological task force battalions of the Territorial Army, popularly known as the Ganga Battalion, based

out of Prayagraj. He said the initiative should not be viewed as a challenge but as a structured and achievable mission aimed at bringing about positive change.

Singh said the task force has put in place a comprehensive action plan with clearly defined goals and measurable outcomes.

"We have submitted our annual, weekly, and daily programmes, which focus on outcome-based, quantifiable, and tangible results. Therefore, with these structures in place, I do not see this as a challenge but as an opportunity for the participation of both the people and the Indian Army," Singh added.

The Yamuna Task Force comprised two officers, five junior commissioned officers and 125 personnel, he said.

The mandate of the task force is to patrol the stretch of the Yamuna in Delhi, which is around 22 km long, spread awareness about the importance of clean rivers and to prevent the throwing of trash and other items in it, the officer said.



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IN FOCUS



A worker plants paddy saplings in a field at Ganjansoo village, in Jammu, Sunday

JK Cong launches ‘padyatra’ in support of statehood demand

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jammu

The Jammu and Kashmir Congress on Sunday launched a five-day ‘padyatra’ here in support of its demand for the restoration of full statehood to the Union Territory.

The ‘padyatra’ under the party’s ongoing campaign ‘Hamari Riyasat, Hamara Haq’ was kicked off by J&K Pradesh Congress Committee president Tariq Hameed Karra along with senior leaders from Jammu West.

‘Hamari Riyasat, Hamara Haq’ is not merely a political slogan but a movement aimed at restoring the democratic and constitutional rights of the people of Jammu and Kashmir, Karra said.

He said despite repeated promises and assurances made by the BJP leadership, the people of J&K continue to be deprived of their full democratic rights and identity. “The Congress will continue its struggle both on the roads and in every democratic forum until statehood is restored,” he said.

Attacking the BJP-led Centre, he alleged that the central government has failed to address the issues of rising inflation, unprecedented

ed unemployment, increasing fuel prices, and economic distress being faced by common citizens.

“The burden of price rise has broken the back of the middle class and poor sections, while the youth are suffering due to lack of employment opportunities and repeated failures in the examination system,” he said.

Referring to the NEET paper leak issue, Karra said the future of lakhs of students has been put at risk due to corruption and mismanagement, and demanded the immediate resignation of the Union education minister, saying moral responsibility cannot be escaped when the credibility of national examinations has been shattered.

The Congress leader said his party stands firmly with the youth, students, farmers, traders, daily wage earners, and every section of society that is suffering under the current policies of the Centre.

“Jammu and Kashmir has witnessed continued uncertainty and administrative disconnect after the downgrading of the erstwhile state into a Union Territory, and the people now feel politically disempowered,” he said.



Indian vessel sinks near Oman, crew rescued

It further said that the vessel is soon expected to berth at Duqm port, located in the southeastern coast of the Gulf country.

On Saturday, the mission confirmed that Uirthanathan had passed away due to medical complications. However, it did not provide details of the medical conditions that led to Uirthanathan’s death.

According to the Forward Seamen’s Union of India, Uirthanathan passed away on June 11 “after falling seriously ill”. On Saturday, they had posted a video clip of a visibly unwell Uirthanathan being offered food by a fellow crew member. Details of the video could not be independently verified. MT Celestial happens to be the same vessel which was stopped by the US Marines for a search drill last month on suspicion of violating the US blockade at the Strait of Hormuz, and later released after directing its crew to alter the its course.

Jewar farmers touch the sky

The delegation, led by Jewar MLA Dharendra Singh, will fly to Lucknow, where they are scheduled to meet the Chief Minister.

“The farmers and agricultural workers who spent their lives cultivating these lands will now undertake their first air journey from the international airport built upon them. This is not merely an air journey. It is a flight of recognition of the dignity of the nation’s food providers. The same hands that nurtured crops and fed the nation will now fasten their seat belts and become participants in India’s new journey of progress and aspiration,” he added.

Their journey is being seen as a symbolic moment as those who once worked on these fields will now become passengers at the airport built on the same land.

TMC rift deepens as Sudip backs rebel MPs

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The internal crisis within the Trinamool Congress intensified on Sunday as Sudip Bandyopadhyay, a close associate of Mamata Banerjee, expressed support for the rebel faction. Dissident Members of Parliament (MPs) met with Union Minister Bhupender Yadav at his residence before requesting the Lok Sabha Speaker to recognise them as the legitimate Trinamool Congress (TMC) parliamentarians.

Bandyopadhyay stated that he decided to align with the dissident group following appeals from rebel MPs and Members of the Legislative Assembly (MLAs). He further clarified that he had not yet signed the letter addressed to Speaker Om Birla and would do so only in the presence of West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari.

The MPs met with Yadav in Delhi to strategise ahead of their scheduled meeting with Speaker Birla on



Monday. This development followed Bandyopadhyay’s decision to join the rebel camp after holding discussions with Amit Shah and Bhupender Yadav in Delhi, despite his reputation as one of Mamata Banerjee’s closest confidants. “I had a meeting with Amit Shah,” Bandyopadhyay told reporters on Sunday. “Most of the MPs and MLAs

wanted this effort to succeed. They wanted the party to keep going with Mamata Banerjee as chief advisor and leader. Their request truly moved me. So, I decided to stay with them,” he said. However, Bandyopadhyay said he still had not signed the letter for Birla. “I will sign only in the presence of the Chief Minister,” he said.

Meanwhile, MPs Saayoni Ghosh and Mala Roy arrived in Delhi before the other TMC MP, Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, indicated that internal discussions were ongoing within the party. Leader of the dissident group, Lok Sabha member Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, indicated that discussions were underway within the party. Rebel MP Jagadish Chandra

Twin accidents claim 12 lives in MP, Maharashtra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In two separate accidents involving a train in Madhya Pradesh and a bus in Maharashtra 12 people lost their lives on Sunday. A rumour of fire on board the Khajuraho-Udaipur Intercity Express train turned to be fatal for three women and a boy, who jumped out on tracks and were run over by another long-distance train in Morena district of Madhya Pradesh on Sunday, officials said.

The incident occurred around 4.15 pm between Hetampur and Dholpur section of Jhansi railway division, they said. These passengers hurriedly got off the train following a chain pull caused by the fire rumour, an official said. While in Solapur in Maharashtra eight people, including four women and four children, were killed



Police, railway officials recovering bodies from the railway tracks after four people were killed after allegedly jumping off the Khajuraho-Udaipur Intercity Express

PTI

while seven others were injured when a pick-up vehicle carrying them plunged into a roadside well.

Police said 15 people were travelling in the vehicle when the incident occurred near Tandulwadi village.

“Four passengers of the Khajuraho-Udaipur Intercity Express (19665) jumped off a general coach, second from

the engine, after panic spread over reports of a fire,” North Central Railway’s Jhansi Division Public Relation Officer Manoj Singh said.

Just then, the Patalkot Express (20424) from Firozpur in Punjab to Seoni in MP, was passing on the adjacent tracks, he added. The four passengers who alighted from the train, failed to notice the

approaching train and were run over by it, leading to their deaths.

The incident triggered panic among other passengers, and railway authorities and police were alerted immediately, he said. The exact cause behind the incident is being probed, Singh said.

As per the preliminary information in the Solapur accident, the pick-up vehicle carrying 15 people fell into a roadside well after the driver lost control. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis has expressed grief over the loss of lives in the accident and announced a financial assistance of Rs 5 lakh to the next of kin of each deceased person. Describing the accident as “extremely unfortunate and tragic”, Fadnavis stated, “I offer my heartfelt condolences to the deceased and share the grief of their families”.

Unfortunate that seers will be probed: Akhilesh on Ram temple donation row

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lucknow

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday said it was a matter of misfortune that “officials” will investigate alleged swindling of the donation money at the Ram Temple.

The Yogi Adityanath government on Saturday constituted an SIT to probe alleged irregularities in donations and financial management of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

Responding to a reporter’s query in Agra, Yadav said, “After the alleged theft of offerings, it is unfortunate that officials will investigate people associated with our religion and temple ... Will officials investigate those who are advancing our religion? What could be a greater misfortune for Sanatan Dharma than this?”

Yadav added, “If something has happened with the offerings made to Lord Ram, then switch off the cameras and discuss it



among yourselves. Return whatever offering was stolen and Lord Ram will forgive you.”

The former Uttar Pradesh chief minister said that officials investigating saints and seers is unacceptable to the followers of Sanatan Dharma. On Saturday, in a cryptic post on X, Yadav suggested that one need not go far to unravel the malfeasance at the temple.

“The root of this conspiracy is not far away. Therefore, there will be no need to go far to take action if the truth is to be uncovered ... If the police are unable to identify the guilty, we can help,” he wrote.

Karnataka CM assures to step up Bairakuppe bridge project

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Wayanad (Kerala)

Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar has assured that steps would be taken to expedite the long-pending Bairakuppe bridge project connecting Kerala and Karnataka, state PWD Minister P K Basheer said on Sunday.

Basheer said Shivakumar conveyed the assurance during a meeting held in Bengaluru and informed him that the proposal would soon be placed before the Karnataka Cabinet.

The proposed interstate bridge across the Kabani river would connect Perikkalloor in Kerala’s Wayanad district with Bairakuppe in Karnataka’s Kodagu district.

According to a statement



issued by Basheer, Shivakumar said directions had already been issued to initiate the required procedures for the project.

The bridge project has remained pending for several decades despite receiving approvals at various levels.

The foundation stone for the bridge was jointly laid on September 22, 1994, by the then chief ministers of Kerala (K Karunakaran) and Karnataka (Veerappa Moily).

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also posed challenges for carriers. The airport has limited aircraft parking capacity and operates within restricted hours, making schedule disruptions harder to manage. If one aircraft occupies a parking position longer than planned, incoming flights may have to be diverted elsewhere. Efforts are reportedly underway to add more parking bays at the airport.

Abhishek moves to block rebel TMC MPs

Third, it says that no group of members can form a separate faction on their own. This action comes as some TMC MPs have expressed concerns about candidate selection and organisational control before 2026. By submitting the letter to the Speaker, the party leadership seeks to prevent any future petition under the anti-defection law that cites a split.

Following its defeat in the West Bengal assembly election, the Mamata Banerjee-led party is experiencing significant dissent among its lawmakers. The dissident group claims support from 22 MPs and plans to meet the Speaker on Monday to seek recognition as a separate parliamentary bloc.

In his letter, party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee asked that the All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) be formally recognised as a single political party in the House, represented only by its authorised leader and whip. He also requested that the party be allowed to present its case before any decision is made regarding communications from dissident MPs.

“Treat the AITC as a single political party represented in the House solely through its duly authorised Leader and Whip, and decline to accord any recognition, status, or facility to any purported separate group or faction of the AITC,” Banerjee said in his letter.

“Afford the AITC an opportunity of being heard before any decision is taken on any communication of the nature referred to above,

should the same be received,” he said.

Banerjee also contended that any merger claim must meet two legal requirements: a merger of the political party and support from two-thirds of its legislators. Meeting only one condition is insufficient under the law. It requires the backing of a majority of the party’s parliamentary strength.

Banerjee stated that the Trinamool Congress reserves the right to initiate proceedings under the anti-defection law for any actions that violate the Tenth Schedule.

Speaking to reporters at Kolkata airport before departing for New Delhi, rebel MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar said two more Lok Sabha members were expected to join the faction, increasing its strength to 22. “We are meeting the Speaker tomorrow and will seek recognition as a separate parliamentary bloc,” she said.

The battle for control of the TMC is unfolding in both Parliament and the West Bengal Assembly. Last week, 64 of the party’s 80 MLAs broke away and secured recognition as a separate legislative formation from Speaker Rathindra Bose, with Ritabrata Banerjee recognised as the Leader of Opposition. The Mamata Banerjee-led faction has challenged that decision before the Calcutta High Court.

Rebel TMC MPs join Tripura-based outfit

The rebel leaders, led by four-time Barasat MP Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, say they left because of governance problems, claims of lawlessness and corruption, and issues within the party.

Some of the main rebel MPs are Satabdi Roy, Saayoni Ghosh, and Prasun Banerjee. They have already met with senior BJP leaders, including Union Minister Bhupender Yadav, at his home in Delhi. Some reports say Adhikari was also part of these meetings.ng support for the NDA and seeking recognition as a separate parliamentary bloc (or even claiming ‘real TMC’ status).

TMC loyalists, including National General Secretary Abhishek Banerjee, immediately countered with their own letter urging the Speaker not to recognise any rebel faction. The rebels’ reported strategy, merging en masse with the small Nationalist Citizens Party, aims to satisfy the anti-defection law’s merger exception. When at least two-thirds of a party’s legislators merge with another party, they are protected from disqualification. After merging with the Nationalist Citizens Party, the group can support or join the NDA without facing immediate legal problems. This is similar to what happened in past party splits, such as with the Shiv Sena or the NCP, but here they are using a small, existing party as a bridge.

The Nationalist Citizens Party is registered but has little influence, making it a good choice for the rebels’ move. Adding 20 MPs could help the NDA in the Lok Sabha and make it easier to pass laws.

The TMC is already weakened by its loss in the West Bengal assembly election and by another rebellion among its MLAs. This has further hurt Mamata Banerjee’s strength in parliament and her national reputation. Loyalists such as Mahua Moitra have called the rebels “greedy, self-serving traitors.” The Speaker’s choice to recognise a separate group or a merger will be crucial. TMC says the rebels are not legitimate because key roles, such as chief whip, have already been given to others. A full legal battle over the party’s name, symbol, and status before the Election Commission is expected.

This change marks a big shift in both West Bengal and national politics. With the BJP now leading the state and the rebels moving toward the NDA, TMC is facing a strong challenge to its control in Bengal. The rebels say their actions are for the “national interest” and Bengal’s progress, but critics call it opportunism after losing the election.

In the next few days, it will become clear whether the Speaker accepts the rebels’ claims, whether the merger with the Nationalist Citizens Party proceeds, and how soon the new group joins the NDA. For now, this is a clear example of political strategy in India’s changing coalition politics.



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GRAPEVINE

VVIP lose sleep over disaster alerts

Last week, people in the national Capital region lost sleep many times due to the newly devised emergency call alerts on mobile phones regarding rain and thunderstorms at midnight. The NDMA and the Department of Telecom's new venture did not even spare a 'prominent VVIP' who lost his sleep through this high-pitched alarm buzz. The very next morning came the order to stop this nuisance testing practice on mobile phones in the name of emergency alert messages and try some other citizen-friendly alarm mechanism. Telecom officials rushed to Sanchar Bhawan to suspend disaster alerts temporarily.

Keyboard Ke Sipahi

On the occasion of 12 years of the Modi Government, a full two-day media briefing was conducted by the Cabinet at Bharat Mandapam. BJP President Nitin Nabin presented a speech on the achievements of the 12 years of the Narendra Modi-led NDA Government. There were different sessions, including one for TV journalists, another for Print journalists and one for social media influencers. In his opening remarks, Nabin indicated print media as the most significant because it sets up a narrative in the making and shaping of a vibrant democracy like India. Another connotation came from BJP Media chief Anil Baluni. "Kalam Ke Sipahi jo ab Keyboard Ke Sipahi Bun Gaye Hain," Baluni quipped brining instant smile to those present in the hall.

Reshuffle to await MPs' exodus

The great reshuffle is about to happen just before the Monsoon session. In the grand theatrical tradition of Indian Cabinet reshuffles – where no one is ever truly fired, merely "relieved of responsibilities to focus on the party" – whispers are once again swirling that two incumbent Cabinet ministers may soon be given important party positions. Grapevine has it that the mega reshuffle would happen once there is clarity on realignments of the sitting Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha MPs from TMC, Shiv Sena (UBT), and some of them from Jharkhand as well. Also, the Government is waiting for the smooth completion of RE-NET exams and the turn of events due to the West Asia crisis affecting the fuel economy.

OVER 6,300 DOLPHINS RECORDED IN FIRST SURVEY

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG) has highlighted signs of ecological revival in the Ganga under the Namami Gange programme, citing large-scale afforestation and the return of key aquatic species, including the endangered Gangetic dolphin.

In a post shared on social media earlier this week to mark 12 years of the Namami Gange programme, the NMCG said, "For decades, Ma Ganga's banks grew thinner, and her water grew quieter. Trees that held the soil disappeared. The dolphin our grandparents saw stopped appearing. The fish a fisherman could once count on became a memory."



The agency said 33,024 hectares of forest now stand along the river's banks and 6,324 Gangetic dolphins have been recorded in India's first nationwide survey of the species.

Explaining the connection between afforestation and biodiversity recovery, the NMCG said, "The two numbers are not separate."

"When the trees come back, the soil holds. When the soil holds, the water clears. When the water clears, the fish come. When the fish come, the dolphin follows," it said.

The NMCG also referred to the return of turtles, otters and hilsa fish to stretches of the river where they had previously declined, describing them as indicators of improving ecological conditions.

"A river is not only water. A river is a forest, a fish, a mammal, a livelihood, all moving together. Twelve years of Namami Gange has begun to put each of those back," the NMCG said.

12 years of affordable, accessible healthcare for all, says PM Modi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said the country has worked to make quality healthcare more affordable and accessible in the past 12 years, and the government will keep working on all such initiatives to build a healthy India.

Modi also said the government feels proud when "India is known as the nation with the world's largest healthcare programme, Ayushman Bharat, which provides top-quality healthcare to the most vulnerable".

"Over the last 12 years, India has worked to make quality healthcare more affordable and accessible," he said in a post on social media.

The prime minister said other efforts like PM Bharatiya Jan Aushadhi



Pariyojana have made medicines, stents and knee implants affordable, and this has helped many people.

At the same time, he said, medical education has also become more accessible to people due to more institutions and seats being available.

"We will keep building on this ground covered so far in order to build a healthy India," he said.

The 'MyGov India,' a flag-

ship citizen engagement platform of the central government, stated that healthcare accessibility is one of the most important investments a nation can make.

"Over the past 12 years, under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership, India has made significant strides to ensure quality healthcare reaches more people, more efficiently, and more affordably. The healthcare ecosystem today

is more accessible, resilient, and future-ready for its citizens," it said.

The MyGov India further said a stronger healthcare system starts with more doctors, better training and wider access to medical education.

"Over the years, aspiring medical professionals have gained opportunities closer to home, including in regions that previously lacked such institutions. The result is a growing pool of skilled healthcare talent ready to serve a healthier India," it said.

For millions of families, the fight against TB is no longer being fought in the shadows, the platform said, adding that through early detection, wider screening, improved treatment access and community participation, India is accelerating its journey towards a TB-free future.

INS Sharda visit boosts India-Sri Lanka Navy ties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An Indian Navy ship, INS Sharda, departed Colombo, Sri Lanka, on Saturday, after a successful port call that further strengthened maritime cooperation and friendship between India and Sri Lanka, the Navy said on Sunday.

Giving details, it said the visit featured a series of professional, training, and sporting engagements with the Sri Lankan Navy.

As part of capacity-building initiatives, Sri Lankan Navy personnel participated in small arms handling, basic firefighting, first aid, and rescue procedures.

During the visit, Rear Admiral Jagath Kumara, Commander Western Naval Area, Sri Lanka Navy, visited the ship and interacted with the crew, reaffirming the strong maritime partnership between the two nations.

Friendly sports fixtures, profession-



al exchanges, and further enhanced interoperability and strengthened bonds between the two services.

During the port call, the Commanding Officer of INS Sharda paid a courtesy call on Santosh Jha, High Commissioner of India to Sri Lanka.

The visit underscored the enduring maritime partnership between India and Sri Lanka and reaffirmed their shared commitment to regional maritime cooperation and security in line with the vision of MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions).

Govt halts seafarer deployment to Gulf conflict zones

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Directorate General of Shipping (DGS) has advised maritime recruitment and placement agencies to restrict deployment of Indian seafarers to conflict areas until further orders, days after three Indian seafarers onboard MT Settebello were killed after the US military strike on the commercial vessel off the Oman coast.

DG Shipping, in a circular, said masters of vessels operating in or transiting through the Gulf region, including the Strait of Hormuz and adjoining waters, are advised to maintain heightened security awareness, closely monitor navigational warnings received and advisories issued from Security agencies, and implement all applicable ship security measures and Company Security Procedures.

"This Directorate further reiterates that all RPSL companies and shipping companies (maritime recruitment and placement agencies) are advised to restrict deployment or send Indian seafarers to conflict areas until further orders. However, companies may carry out



crew change in emergency situations with the consent of crew members," it said.

The circular noted that recent developments in the Gulf region, particularly in and around the Strait of Hormuz and the Gulf of Oman, have resulted in multiple security incidents involving merchant vessels carrying Indian seafarers. Incidents involving MT Marivex, MT Settebello and MV Jalveer during the past few days have highlighted the increasing risks faced by commercial ships operating in the region.

It added that the

Directorate General of Shipping is closely monitoring the evolving situation in coordination with the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Ministry of External Affairs, Indian Navy, Indian Missions abroad and other concerned stakeholders to ensure the safety and welfare of Indian seafarers.

The circular asked maritime companies and stakeholders to exercise the highest degree of vigilance and caution while operating in the conflict zone.

India on Wednesday summoned the US charge d'affaires to strongly protest a US

military attack on a commercial vessel off the Oman coast that left three of the 24 Indian crew members missing.

In its statement on Wednesday, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) condemned the attack.

"We condemn the attack on the commercial vessel Settebello off the coast of Oman, earlier today. Of the 24 Indian crew onboard, 21 Indians have been rescued thus far, and three Indians are reportedly missing," it had said.

The incident came amid renewed hostilities between Iran and Israel.

India's space economy to hit \$45 billion in a decade: Jitendra Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Science & Technology and Earth Sciences, and Minister of State in the Prime Minister's Office, Department of Atomic Energy, Jitendra Singh has said India's space economy is poised to grow from the current \$8-9 billion to nearly \$40-45 billion over the next decade, driven by policy reforms, growing private participation and a rapidly expanding innovation ecosystem.

Addressing a press conference here, the minister said the transformation of India's space sector reflects a larger change taking place across the country, where science and technology have moved beyond laboratories to become part of the national consciousness.

He said one of the most significant achievements of recent years has been the growing connection between science and society, with citizens



increasingly seeing themselves as stakeholders in India's scientific progress.

Singh said the growing prominence of science and technology in public discourse reflects the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who has consistently brought science-driven initiatives into the national mainstream through his Independence Day addresses.

He said programmes such as Swachh Bharat, Digital India, Digital Health, Deep Ocean Mission and Gaganyaan have helped position science and innovation at the centre of India's development journey.

The Minister said India's growing capabilities in frontier sectors such as space,

atomic energy and advanced technologies have strengthened the country's global standing. He said the confidence generated by these achievements has enhanced the credibility of indigenous technologies and reinforced India's position as a trusted technology partner.

Singh said recent technological achievements have demonstrated India's ability to excel in emerging domains where advanced technologies increasingly shape strategic and economic outcomes.

The growing acceptance of Indian technologies and products across international markets reflects the strength of the country's scientific and technological capabilities, he added.

Ayush ministry sets Guinness record with live yoga stream

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a landmark achievement ahead of the International Day of Yoga (IDY) 2026, the Ministry of Ayush created a new Guinness World Record on Sunday for the "Most Viewers for a YouTube Live Yoga Stream", with 4,35,831 viewers joining a special global online yoga session streamed live through the ministry's channel on the platform.

The record attempt was organised as part of the ministry's outreach activities for IDY 2026 and witnessed enthusiastic participation from yoga practitioners, students, institutions, professionals and wellness enthusiasts from across India and around the world.

The event featured the Common Yoga Protocol (CYP)



and reinforced the ministry's vision of promoting yoga as a daily practice through the "Yoga 365" movement, according to an official statement.

The Ministry of Ayush recorded 4,35,831 verified viewers, surpassing the previous Guinness World Record of 2,46,252 viewers set in 2024.

"The new record exceeded the previous benchmark by 1,89,579 viewers, establishing a new global record for the largest viewership of a YouTube live yoga stream,"

the statement said.

Addressing participants, Union Ayush Minister Prataprao Jadhav congratulated citizens across the world for contributing to the achievement.

"Today's achievement demonstrates the extraordinary power of yoga to connect people across regions, cultures and nations through a shared commitment to health and well-being. This new Guinness World Record reflects the growing global acceptance of

Rahul hits out at PM Modi over US attacks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Sunday criticised Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the US' statements after three Indian sailors were killed in American attacks on ships, with party leader Rahul Gandhi saying the "compromised PM" listens "like an obedient servant" and "complices with the 'orders'".

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge also attacked the prime minister over his "silence" on the killing of the three Indian seafarers, and alleged that no proof is required that he had "belittled" India's global

S Jaishankar on June 12.

Gandhi slammed the prime minister, saying "our compromised PM" listens like an "obedient servant" and complies with the "orders".

The Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha also said that "a compromised PM" will not defend the nation's honour because he is beholden to those who insult the country.

His remarks come a day after the US said it conveyed to India that any violation of its blockade in the Strait of Hormuz and illicit transport of Iranian oil will not be tolerated.

US Secretary of State Rubio conveyed this to Jaishankar,



standing and sovereignty.

The Congress also said India must put off the upcoming visit of US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer and asserted that any self-respecting nation will do more than mere phone calls and press statements to defend its sovereignty against "bullies".

With Prime Minister Modi set to meet US President Donald Trump in France this week, the Opposition party asked whether he will raise India's strongest condemnation over the sailors' killing in a US attack on a ship off the Oman coast, and the "threatening and really unacceptable" language used by US Secretary of State Marco Rubio in his conversation with External Affairs Minister

who spoke with him on Friday to lodge a strong protest against the death of three Indian nationals in US attacks on ships off the coast of Oman.

In a post in Hindi on social media, Gandhi said, "Just days after three Indian sailors were killed in American attacks, there is neither regret nor apology. On the contrary, the US continues to issue orders."

"Read their words: 'Obey US military orders immediately'. No violation 'will be tolerated,'" he said.

In another post in Hindi, he referred to the death of an Indian national due to medical complications aboard a vessel currently docked at the Duqm Port in Oman.

CIC orders CBSE to reveal board exam tender data under RTI Act

MOHIT SAINI
■ New Delhi

The Central Information Commission (CIC) has directed the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) to disclose "point-wise categorical" information permissible under the RTI Act related to expenditure on exams and details of answer books, including the tendering and procurement process, for Class 10 and Class 12 board examinations.

After setting aside the CBSE's earlier denial of information under the RTI, the transparency panel asked it to furnish revised replies and said that the information exempt from disclosure may be redacted or masked under Section 10 of the RTI Act, while any denial under Section 8(1)(d) should be properly justified.

The case arose from an RTI application seeking details of answer books used in Class 10 and Class 12 board examinations during the 2023-24 and 2024-25 sessions, including paper quality, number of pages, size, purchase cost, total expenditure, GST payments and details of the tender process for procurement of answer sheets. In its response, the CBSE disclosed certain specifications of the answer books, stating that the paper used ranged from 60 GSM to 120 GSM, answer books contained 8, 20, 32, 40 or 48 pages and were available in sizes of 22 x 28 cm and 37.5 x 54.5 cm.

The board also said records regarding the weight of individual answer books were not



maintained.

However, information relating to the purchase cost of answer books, the number purchased and total expenditure incurred on procurement was denied under Section 8(1)(e) of the RTI Act.

On queries regarding the tender process, names of participating firms, rates quoted and vendor selection, the CBSE said the matter was related to "confidential" and "sensitive" activities of board examinations and claimed exemption under sections 8(1)(d), 8(1)(e) and 8(1)(g) of the Act.

The board also stated that expenditure data for examination fees was maintained on a financial year basis instead of academic sessions and declined to provide specific expenditure details.

It also informed the applicant that expenditure on practical examinations was booked under a broader expenditure head and could not be segregated separately.

The appellant challenged the response before the CIC, arguing that a larger public

interest and transparency warranted disclosure of information relating to procurement and expenditure.

Information Commissioner Sudha Rani Relangi observed that the core issue in the appeal was the denial of information related to the "tender process for purchase of answer sheet and other related stationery materials" despite the appellant's contention that a larger public interest justified disclosure.

The Commission found that the Central Public Information Officer (CPIO) had denied information under multiple exemption clauses "without giving any proper justification in this regard". It also noted that the CPIO neither appeared during the hearing nor filed any written statement to justify the denial of information. "Accordingly, the impugned reply of the CPIO dated March 18, 2025 in the absence of any justification for denial of the information sought is hereby set aside," the CIC said.

Referring to transparency in public procurement, the

Commission observed that "time and again" the Supreme Court and the CIC had emphasised that such exemptions must be construed strictly to ensure accountability in public procurement and contracts by public authorities.

"Now, considering the averments of the Appellant during the hearing

Regarding irregularity on such tenders, the Commission deems it fit to direct CPIO to revisit the contents of the RTI application in question and provide a revised point-wise categorical replies along with relevant permissible information that can be provided as per the provisions of the RTI Act, 2005," the CIC said.

The CIC further said the CPIO ought to have disclosed permissible information while redacting only those portions exempt from disclosure under the RTI Act. "Information which are exempted from disclosure should be redacted/masked under Section 10 of the RTI Act, 2005. In case the information sought is covered under Section 8 (1)(d) of the RTI Act, 2005, the CPIO may justify such denial by giving justification under Section 19 (5) of the RTI Act, 2005," the order said. Section 8 (1) (d) deals with information such as commercial confidence, trade secrets or intellectual property, the disclosure of which would harm the competitive position of a third party, unless the competent authority is satisfied that a larger public interest warrants the disclosure of such information. (PTI)

A final video call: Bihar families mourn IAF personnel killed in Assam crash

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The last memories are now frozen on mobile phone screens. One mother recalls her son smiling during a brief video call; another treasures a photo he sent from inside an aircraft before an IAF plane crash in Assam killed five personnel, including their sons.

Flight Lieutenant Shubham Kumar from Bihar's Jehanabad and Agniveervayu Danish Alam of Bhojpur were among those killed in the Antonov An-32 transport aircraft crash on Saturday. The phones that carried cheerful video calls and photographs on Saturday morning soon delivered devastating news.

According to family members, the flight lieutenant had spoken to his mother in Banwariya village via video call around 9 am on Saturday.

"Kumar looked cheerful and normal. He said that he was in a hurry and would speak at length later," a family member recalled. His younger brother, Satyam, said the family first learnt about the accident around 11 am, but found it difficult to believe.

The grim reality sank in only after repeated attempts to reach him on his



mobile phone failed, and officials confirmed the news. The son of a farmer and a homemaker, Kumar had fulfilled his dream of serving the nation when he was selected as a Flying Officer in the Indian Air Force in 2021.

Family members said marriage talks had recently begun, but he chose to put them on hold, insisting that his career and service responsibilities came first.

Back in his village, locals remember him as a humble young man who never forgot his roots and greeted everyone warmly whenever he came home on leave. Villagers now await the arrival of his mortal remains to pay their last respects.

In Kayamnagar village of Bhojpur district, Danish Alam's family is clinging to another final memory — a photograph

he sent from inside an aircraft on Saturday morning.

"He had spoken to us over a video call on Friday evening, and he seemed very happy. "On Saturday morning, he sent us a photo of himself sitting inside an aircraft. We later went to the Ara market, and while we were there, news of the crash reached us. We rushed back home," said his mother, Akhtari Begum. Alam was her only son. Begum has two daughters. "It was his dream to serve in the Indian Air Force. He planned his studies on his own and worked hard to achieve that goal," Begum said.

Friends and neighbours described him as a determined young man who carried the hopes of his family. His friend Sujit Tiwari appealed for financial assistance for the bereaved family.

"Alam was the family's biggest support. His elder sister is yet to be married, his mother remains unwell, and the family has very limited means.

"His father works in a private job earning around `10,000 a month. We hope the Government extends assistance to them," Tiwari said. As news of the crash spread across the two villages, grief gave way to an outpouring of pride for the young men who had chosen to serve in uniform.

Rajasthan to use AI surveillance system in wildlife sanctuaries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jaipur

Rajasthan's forest department is set to deploy an AI-based surveillance system across wildlife sanctuaries to curb poaching and monitor tiger and wildlife movement, officials said.

The anti-poaching system will use thermal and optical cameras, drones, wireless communication networks, solar-powered systems and advanced surveillance software to provide round-the-clock monitoring of protected forest areas. The project is being funded and implemented by the Department of Information Technology and Communication and RajCOMP Info Services Limited, according to the forest department.

A total of 56 surveillance systems and five drones were installed in key protected areas during the first phase. These include 12 setups in Ranthambore Tiger Reserve, 16 in Sariska Tiger Reserve, 16 in Mukundra Hills Tiger Reserve, four in Jawai Leopard Sanctuary and eight in Jhalana Leopard



Reserve.

Existing infrastructure is being upgraded with the latest technology, including improved camera networks, surveillance software and communication systems, to strengthen monitoring capabilities, the official said.

In the second phase, 15 new surveillance setups are being installed in other protected areas. These include three each in Ramgarh Vishdhari Tiger Reserve, Jamwa Ramgarh Wildlife Sanctuary and Todgarh-Raoli Wildlife Sanctuary, four in Kumbhalgarh Wildlife Sanctuary and two in Keoladeo National Park.

The installations are expected to be completed within the next three months.

The objective is to estab-

lish a 24x7 monitoring system that can track the movement of tigers and other wildlife species in real time, officials said.

The system will also help prevent human-wildlife conflict. Whenever a tiger or any other wild animal moves out of the forest area towards nearby settlements, alerts will be sent instantly to the mobile phones of concerned forest officers and field staff, enabling quick response.

The surveillance network is also expected to strengthen efforts against wildlife crimes. Forest officials will receive immediate alerts if any suspicious activity related to poaching is detected.

According to officials, the dual-sensor cameras being installed can capture activities within an eight-kilometre range and provide 360-degree coverage.

The system can identify wildlife species, individuals, vehicles and other objects.

The cameras will also be capable of identifying individual tigers based on their stripe patterns and provide the precise location of any detected activity.

US-based Christian missionary booked under UAPA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

A case has been registered against a US-based organisation and six others after the ED lodged a complaint alleging illegal utilisation of foreign funds through a network of foreign debit cards, including in Left Wing Extremism (LWE)-affected areas of the country.

Based on the complaint filed by ED Assistant Director Sunil Kumar Sinhmar, Kothanur Police in Bengaluru registered on June 11 under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA). The FIR names Jonathan S Rajan, Micah Mark, Ajit Verghese



Mathai, Varghese Chacko, Bablu Kurmi, Supreme Joy, US-based The Timothy Initiative and others as accused.

In the complaint, the ED alleged that searches conducted on April 18 and 19 under provisions of the Income Tax Act and the Foreign Exchange Management Act revealed that the accused, in associa-

tion with TTI, used foreign-origin debit cards issued by a US bank to withdraw and utilise foreign funds across India. The agency alleged that approximately ₹92.55 crore (\$99,95,240) was utilised illegally during the six-month period from November 2025 to April 2026 in violation of FEMA and FCRA provisions.

According to the FIR, Micah Mark was detained at Bengaluru's Kempegowda International Airport on April 18 and was allegedly found in possession of 24 foreign debit cards. More than 1,000 such cards had been distributed across India, many carrying the common name 'Santosh Kumar' while using regional identifiers such as "NE-1", "NE-

2" and "Southern Region-1".

The ED further alleged that suspicious cash withdrawals were detected in LWE-affected regions of Chhattisgarh. The FIR states that approximately Rs 6.34 crore is estimated to have been withdrawn in areas including Dhamtari and Bastar over the past few years.

The complaint alleged that the use of foreign debit cards for large-scale cash withdrawals indicated the involvement of an organised network and that the funds were allegedly channelled into Naxalite-influenced regions. It stated that such activities constituted an unlawful activity under the UAPA and posed a threat to India's security and economic integrity.

Kerala CM criticises VCs for attending RSS event

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Sunday criticised the participation of three Vice Chancellors in a function addressed by RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat as part of the organisation's centenary celebrations and demanded an apology from them. In a Facebook post, the chief minister said the participation of the Vice Chancellors in the event was unbefitting of their office and inconsistent with Kerala's educational traditions. Vice Chancellors of Kerala, MG and Malayalam Universities attended the RSS centenary celebrations held in Thiruvananthapuram on Saturday.

"The participation of three Vice Chancellors in the meeting addressed by RSS Sarsangchalak Mohan Bhagwat as part of the RSS centenary celebrations is being viewed with utmost seriousness. The Vice Chancellors have committed a grave lapse," he said.

Satheesan said Kerala society held the office of Vice Chancellor in high esteem and alleged that their participation in a programme of an RSS leader who propagated extreme communal views had diminished the dignity associated with the post.

"Kerala society has great respect for the office of Vice Chancellor. Their participation in the programme of an RSS leader who espouses extreme communalism is not in keeping with the dignity of



that office," he said.

The chief minister said actions that promote communalism would not be accepted regardless of who was responsible. "Any action that encourages communalism will not be accepted. It will not be tolerated," he said. He demanded that the three Vice Chancellors who attended the RSS programme apologise to the people of Kerala.

Meanwhile, Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan also expressed concern over the Vice Chancellors' participation in the RSS event and alleged that it reflected attempts to expand the Sangh Parivar's influence in the higher education sector.

Addressing a press conference, the former chief minister said the participation of three Vice Chancellors in the programme attended by Bhagwat was a matter of grave concern. "Three Vice Chancellors from Kerala universities participated in that event. This is a matter that secular Kerala views with utmost seriousness," he said.

Vijayan said concerns were already being raised about attempts to impose Sangh Parivar agendas in universities and alleged that the participation of Vice Chancellors in RSS programme had heightened those concerns.

LDF accuses UDF of political vendetta, alleges Cong-BJP nexus

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

The LDF on Sunday accused the UDF Government of pursuing a campaign of "political vendetta" since assuming office and said that several recent administrative decisions violated established norms and democratic practices.

In a statement, LDF convenor TP Ramakrishnan alleged that transfers of officials were being carried out at the behest of pro-government organisations, disregarding established criteria and procedures.

"It has not even been a full month since the UDF



assumed power in Kerala. Since taking office, numerous actions have already been taken as part of a political vendetta," he alleged.

Ramakrishnan also criticised the Government's handling of communicable disease outbreaks, including Nipah, and questioned the transfer of the Director of

Health Services (DHS).

"When infectious diseases, including Nipah, broke out in the past, the models demonstrated by Kerala to combat them were recognised worldwide. Disregarding these experiences, the actions taken by

Health Minister K Muralaitharan have already

triggered intense protests," he said.

He alleged that the DHS, who was responsible for coordinating disease-control activities, had been transferred and demoted based on "fabricated allegations."

The LDF leader said the Opposition was prepared to support all genuine efforts to contain infectious diseases. "We will extend support to all correct measures taken to prevent epidemics," he added.

Ramakrishnan also targeted the Government over a series of appointments made after it assumed office.

He referred to the appointment of a close relative of

Electricity Minister Sunny Joseph as Additional Private Secretary and alleged that the appointment had to be withdrawn following public criticism.

He further alleged that the appointment of Advocate KB Pradeep as Special Pleader for the Devaswom Department was aimed at weakening a gold loss case in which the lawyer had appeared for an accused. Although the lawyer had resigned from the post, Ramakrishnan said the Government must clarify whether any information related to the case had been accessed or leaked during the period of appointment.

Four traditional Jharkhand crafts, including Munda jewellery, receive GI tags

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

Jharkhand's Bhagaiya silk, Kuchai silk, Munda jewellery, and bamboo craft products have received the Geographical Indication (GI) tag, an official statement said on Sunday.

National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD), in the statement, said it was a significant milestone for the artisans and weavers of Jharkhand.

"Four products nurtured and promoted through sustained interventions of the NABARD have secured GI recognition. These include Bhagaiya silk, Kuchai silk, Munda jewellery, and Jharkhand bamboo craft, marking a major achievement in the preservation



and promotion of the state's unique traditional heritage and rural economy," it said.

The GI recognition is the culmination of years of focused efforts undertaken by the bank in collaboration with producer groups, artisans, self-help groups, farmer producer organisations, Government departments, technical institutions and

other stakeholders, the statement said.

NABARD claimed it played a catalytic role in identifying the unique characteristics of these traditional products, organising producers, strengthening value chains, supporting documentation, facilitating stakeholder consultations and providing critical handholding through-

out the GI registration process.

The recognition of Bhagaiya silk and Kuchai silk brings national attention to Jharkhand's rich sericulture traditions. These silk varieties, deeply rooted in local knowledge systems and indigenous craftsmanship, represent generations of skill passed down within rural communities, the statement said.

The GI status will help protect their authenticity, improve market visibility and enable producers to command premium value for their products.

"Similarly, GI recognition accorded to Munda jewellery celebrates the distinctive artistic traditions of the Munda tribal community. Characterised by its unique motifs, craftsmanship and

cultural significance, the jewellery embodies the rich tribal heritage of Jharkhand. The GI tag will contribute towards preserving this traditional knowledge while creating enhanced livelihood opportunities for tribal artisans," the statement said.

The inclusion of Jharkhand bamboo craft acknowledges the creativity and craftsmanship of rural artisans who transform locally available bamboo resources into a wide range of utility and decorative products. The recognition is expected to promote sustainable livelihoods, encourage enterprise development and strengthen market access for bamboo artisans across the State, it said.

NABARD said that over the years, it has consistently worked towards the promo-

Andhra CM visits Singapore to boost investments



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu on Sunday left for Singapore on a two-day visit aimed at strengthening bilateral economic partnerships, attracting investments and reviewing ongoing collaborations for the State.

As per the official schedule, the Chief Minister departed from Bengaluru and is expected to reach Singapore later in the evening. "The Chief Minister left for Singapore on a two-day visit focused on attracting investments, strengthening economic partnerships and reviewing ongoing collaborations related to Andhra Pradesh's development initiatives," said an official press release.

The Chief Minister will attend various meetings and investment-related engagements on June 15 and 16 as part of the State's outreach efforts.

On June 15, Naidu is scheduled to meet Singapore Prime Minister Lawrence Wong and interact with industrialists to discuss areas of cooperation and investment opportunities. He will also participate in meetings with business leaders and representatives from various sectors during the visit. On June 16, the Chief Minister will participate in and address the Leadership Plenary at the World Cities Summit. Later, he will attend a Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) business roadshow and interact with industrialists as part of Andhra Pradesh's investment promotion programme.

tion of indigenous products, traditional crafts and rural enterprises through cluster development, producer institution strengthening, skill development, design interventions, market linkage initiatives and branding support.

Deepmala Ghosh, Chief General Manager, NABARD Jharkhand regional office, said the GI recognition is a matter of pride for Jharkhand, as these products represent the State's rich traditional knowledge, craftsmanship and cultural heritage. The GI tag not only provides recognition and commercial value to such products but also encourages younger generations to continue producing these traditional crafts, thereby ensuring their preservation, she said.



Editor's
TAKE

G7 Summit: Yet another bid to reset world order

As global fault lines deepen, the G7 returns to where it was born – France with an agenda to revamp world order and reaffirm its relevance

There is a certain poetry in the setting. The Group of Seven, born out of oil shocks in 1975, reconvenes in Évian-les-Bains, France, from June 15 to 17, in a year marked by geopolitical fragmentation, and renewed questions about the role of the forum itself. The anxieties may be the same as fifty years ago, but the stage has become far more complex.

France has carefully constructed its summit priorities around addressing macroeconomic imbalances, strengthening economic security and critical mineral supply chains, and reforming international development partnerships. President Macron has been unusually ambitious in his G7 presidency, seeking to push the grouping beyond its traditional comfort zones. He has invited Chinese representatives to a video call to address global imbalances – a bold move that signals Paris's desire for genuine multilateralism rather than performative solidarity. Artificial intelligence is high on the G7 agenda, and Macron's decision to invite OpenAI's Sam Altman to summit discussions underlines his intent to position France as Europe's AI powerhouse. Trade tensions, energy insecurity, sovereign debt crises, and the fallout from the Iran war are all expected to be on the table. The attendance of President Donald Trump, however, adds its own layer of uncertainty to the summit's outcome. Trump's transactional instincts and scepticism of multilateral frameworks have a way of rewriting summit scripts. France also wants to put dialogue, crisis-response, and renewed multilateralism at the heart of its G7 presidency, themes that sound aspirational given today's fractured world order.

The Iran crisis, West Asia, and the security of commercial shipping lanes will inevitably dominate back-corridor conversations. Among the most anticipated moments of the summit is what will transpire on its sidelines between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Trump. The talks will be the first in-person meeting between Modi and Trump. The backdrop is complicated. India-US ties have faced occasional friction over trade policies, India's purchases of Russian oil despite the personal bonhomie between the two leaders. New Delhi has bristled at the last claim in particular, viewing it as an overreach. Trump, meanwhile, congratulated Modi on becoming India's longest-serving elected Prime Minister, reflecting his personal rapport with him. The two leaders are expected to discuss the stalled India-US trade framework, with New Delhi eager to reduce the tariff burden on Indian exports. Yet the ghost of last year's Canada G7 looms – when Modi arrived ready to negotiate, only for Trump to leave the summit early. Modi's visit is expected to reinforce New Delhi's efforts to position itself as a leading voice of the Global South and an influential stakeholder in shaping future rules around artificial intelligence, economic cooperation, and sustainable development. That is a long-term diplomatic investment worth far more than any single meeting. Évian may not resolve the world's crises. But how the leaders navigate their disagreements – and what Modi and Trump signal to each other behind closed doors – will be crucial for Indian subcontinent.

Modi@12: Laying the foundations of a Viksit Bharat

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi completes twelve years in office, becoming India's longest-serving Prime Minister in independent India's history, assessments of his legacy continue to evoke both admiration and criticism



JAGMOHAN
SINGH RAJU

With completion of twelve years in office, Shri Narendra Modi has become the longest serving Prime Minister of independent India. He has proved to be a transformational leader who has restored national confidence, accelerated development and elevated India's standing in the world. Critics question aspects of his governance, institutional approach and political style. Yet beyond the partisan debate lies a larger and more enduring question: what has India become after twelve years of the Modi era?

The answer is not that India has already become Viksit Bharat, a developed nation. No country of India's size and complexity can complete such a journey in little more than a decade. Rather, the more persuasive argument is that the foundations of a Viksit Bharat have been laid in these twelve years. The significance of the Modi era lies in the creation of economic, infrastructural, digital, social and strategic foundations upon which a developed India can be built over the coming decades. The scale of this transformation can perhaps be captured through a few numbers. India has risen from the world's tenth-largest economy to become the fourth largest. More than 58 crore citizens have been brought into the formal banking system through Jan Dhan accounts. Over 15 crore rural households have received tap-water connections, more than 10 crore poor women have received LPG connections, nearly 12 crore toilets have been constructed, and an estimated 25 crore Indians have moved out of multidimensional poverty. Taken individually, these figures represent efficient governance. Taken together, they tell a larger story: the laying of foundations for a more prosperous, inclusive and capable India. Beneath these achievements lies a deeper transformation. The central theme of the Modi era has been the strengthening of India's state capacity-the ability of government to identify beneficiaries, deliver services, build infrastructure, respond to crises and pursue national objectives. In many ways, the journey of the past twelve years can be described as a movement from entitlement to empowerment, from leakage to delivery, from policy paralysis to execution, and from a hesitant India to a more confident India. The first of these foundations is economic strength. In 2014, India was frequently described as a country of immense promise struggling to realise its potential. Twelve years later, India stands among the fastest-growing major economies in the world, recording average annual growth of around 7 per cent. Economic growth alone does not create a developed nation, but no nation has become developed



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without sustained economic expansion. The second foundation is infrastructure. The past twelve years have witnessed a sustained effort to close India's infrastructure gap. National highways have expanded by nearly 60 per cent, port capacity has doubled, 88 airports have been operationalised in smaller cities and over 7.8 lakh kilometres of rural roads have been completed. Dedicated freight corridors have become operational and railway modernisation has accelerated. These are not merely construction statistics. They reflect the enhanced capacity of the Indian state to conceive, finance and execute projects at scale. Another important foundation has been the renewed emphasis on manufacturing. Through initiatives such as Make in India and Production Linked Incentive schemes, India has sought to strengthen domestic production capabilities and reduce strategic dependence in critical sectors. From electronics and mobile phones to defence production and semiconductors, the objective has been to create the productive capacity necessary for a developed economy. The third foundation is digital transformation. The JAM Trinity-Jan Dhan, Aadhaar and Mobile-has fundamentally changed the relationship between citizen and state. India's digital public infrastructure is now studied across the world, while UPI has made digital payments routine even among small traders and rural households. More importantly, technology has enabled the state to deliver services and monitor outcomes with a degree of precision that was previously impossible. The fourth foundation is social welfare and inclusion. For decades, India aspired to be a welfare state but often struggled to ensure that benefits reached intended recipients. The opening of 58 crore Jan Dhan accounts represents far more than a banking initiative; it signifies the inclusion of millions who previously stood outside the formal economy. The real significance lies not merely in the opening of

accounts but in the state's ability to reach previously invisible citizens and deliver benefits directly to them. Similarly, LPG connections, toilets, housing assistance, tap-water connections and healthcare coverage have sought to improve the quality of life of those at the bottom of the social pyramid.

The fifth foundation is state capacity itself. The true test of governance is not the announcement of schemes but the ability to implement them. The government was able to transfer assistance directly into bank accounts, distribute food grains at enormous scale and administer one of the largest vaccination programmes in human history. Such outcomes were possible because the institutional architecture for delivery had already been established.

The sixth foundation is national security. Development requires stability, and stability requires security. India today appears more confident in protecting its interests than it did a decade ago. Major terrorist incidents have declined significantly, border infrastructure has improved, Left Wing Extremism has receded dramatically and is now confined to a much smaller geographical footprint, defence modernisation has accelerated and internal security challenges have become more manageable. India is today safer, more resilient and better prepared than it was twelve years ago.

The seventh foundation is India's global standing. The India of 2026 enjoys greater international stature than the India of 2014. Its voice carries greater weight in global forums, its G20 Presidency demonstrated diplomatic confidence and organisational capability, and its growing strategic partnerships have strengthened its position in an increasingly multipolar world. The world no longer sees India merely as a country with potential; it increasingly sees India as a country shaping outcomes.

Perhaps the most important foundation, however, is confidence. Nations rise not only through economic indicators but through belief in their own capabilities. Whether through infrastructure, digital innovation, welfare delivery, space exploration or diplomacy, India increasingly behaves like a nation that expects to succeed. Confidence alone does not create prosperity, but prosperity rarely emerges in its absence. Yet it is important to distinguish between laying foundations and completing construction. Twelve years is not enough to transform a civilisation-sized nation into a fully developed country. It is, however, sufficient time to establish the pillars upon which future progress can rest. History will ultimately deliver the final verdict. But when historians look back at this period, they may conclude that the Modi era will be remembered less for any individual scheme and more for the foundations it laid-foundations of economic strength, digital capability, social inclusion, national security and, above all, national confidence-for the emergence of a Viksit Bharat.



The writer is former IFS officer and Chairman of Centre for Resource Management and Environment

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Deserve God as a doer in life



AJIT KUMAR
BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

In this article, I will try to explain about who is the actual doer though we feel that we are. It will surprise almost all that we, souls, don't accomplish anything by ourselves; we only desire and decide, being very minute and subtle souls. For doing any act, gross senses are required except in case of God, who does everything with His 'ichcha shakti' (Divine Will Power). We can understand this phenomenon with an example of a rich man. He desires to build a large manufacturing plant. What does he do? He thinks about it and has a subtle plan for it. But for this plan to take physical shape, he needs lots of men, machinery, etc. Yes, his own body will also be used, but let us remember that his body is part of the material nature, given temporarily for one lifetime; it is not permanently his. A soul always remains small



and subtle. There are three entities involved in doing any physical act, if we consider our bodies as separate, though they are parts of the material nature. The second is the material nature, created by God to keep the earth planet habitable with energy, air, water, fertile land, etc. The third and the most important entity is God – the Creator. These three do all acts in various percentages. For non-devotees, there are only two entities, that is the body and the material nature. Human body consists of gross senses, subtle mind, intelligence, ego, consciousness and, most importantly, personal nature. Shocking as it may seem, personal nature is also part of the material nature and is fixed at any given time. All our acts are driven by it. So

who is the actual doer? The answer has to be the material nature in this case. Now let us see what happens in case of devotees of God, those who have taken shelter of God. God takes charge and micromanages lives of His devotees. It means that there are now three entities involved in doing anything with God as the Karta (doer). This gives enormous advantages, which are beyond what we can imagine. Because God is Omnipotent, Omniscient, Controller, Owner, Everything. Whatever God is involved in will be successful. God, ultimately, liberates these fortunate souls. What happens to non-devotees? Under control of the material nature, they are forever living in illusion. They run after material successes, which never satisfy. And the worst thing it does is to give a false impression to the eternally small soul of having becoming big. In this mind-set, a soul makes big mistakes and helplessly suffers repeated cycle of birth and death.

What is the conclusion? We should all take shelter of God and try to remain there. Not only does God liberate but the present life also runs smoothly, which only God can ensure. Otherwise, be ready to suffer during this life and continue to suffer in future lives also. We must qualify to get God as Karta in our lives to avoid such misfortune.



The writer is a spiritual teacher

PIC TALK



A woman walks past a banner of International footballers Cristiano Ronaldo, Lionel Messi, Neymar Jr, in Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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STRENGTHENING INDIA'S DEFENSIVE SHIELD

The successful trial of India's multilayered Ballistic Missile Defence (BMD) system marks a major milestone in strengthening the nation's security architecture. By demonstrating its ability to intercept hostile missiles at various stages of flight, the system significantly enhances India's preparedness against evolving security challenges. This achievement reflects the remarkable capabilities of India's defence scientists and research institutions. The development of such sophisticated indigenous technology underlines the country's commitment to self-reliance in critical strategic sectors and reduces dependence on imported defence systems. In an increasingly uncertain geopolitical environment, an effective missile defence shield is essential for safeguarding national interests. Beyond protecting key installations and densely populated areas, it strengthens India's deterrence capability and contributes to regional strategic stability. The successful BMD test is a matter of national pride, showcasing India's growing technological prowess and scientific excellence.

While maintaining a robust defensive posture, India must continue to uphold its long-standing commitment to peace, dialogue and regional cooperation. A strong defence capability, coupled with responsible diplomacy, remains vital for preserving the nation's sovereignty and ensuring long-term security.

RUKMA SHARMA, JALANDHAR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Hope for diplomacy in the Iran Crisis

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's assertion that a peace agreement between the United States and Iran could be finalised soon has raised hopes of a diplomatic breakthrough after months of tensions and negotiations. According to Sharif, both sides are closer to an agreement than ever before, with discussions progressing towards the final stages. He expressed appreciation for the continued engagement of Washington and Tehran and voiced optimism that the proposed accord would promote long-term regional stability. Reports suggest that negotiations have focused on crucial issues such as Iran's nuclear programme, sanctions relief, management of enriched uranium stockpiles and ensuring the security of the Strait of Hormuz. Pakistan has emerged as an important intermediary since the conflict began in February, hosting talks aimed at facilitating dialogue between the two sides. While Iranian officials have indicated progress, they have also cautioned that the proposed framework remains under review until formally finalised. Given the wider implications for regional peace, global markets and maritime security, a successful agreement would be welcomed by the international community. Sustained diplomacy remains the best path to prevent further escalation

A Waiting for peace over conflict

The US President Donald Trump's repeated threats of military action against Iran resemble the experience of waiting endlessly for a train whose arrival is repeatedly announced but continually delayed. Each announcement raises expectations, only to be followed by another postponement. Eventually, passengers may even learn that the train has been cancelled altogether. While such uncertainty can be frustrating, the cancellation of military action would undoubtedly be preferable to the devastating consequences of war. If a strike against Iran is ultimately avoided, countless lives could be spared despite criticism over the prolonged suspense and shifting rhetoric. This situation recalls Samuel Beckett's Waiting for Godot, where anticipation itself becomes the central experience. The prolonged expectation, uncertainty and speculation surrounding possible military action have shaped international discourse in much the same way. For the leader of the world's most powerful nation, exercising restraint may ultimately prove wiser than pursuing irreversible conflict. Diplomatic engagement, however imperfect, offers a more constructive path than military escalation. In matters of war and peace, patience and prudence often serve humanity better than hasty decisions with far-reaching consequences.

R.S. NARULA, | PATIALA

Jaspal Rana's enduring sporting legacy

The sudden demise of Jaspal Rana has deeply saddened the nation. India has lost one of its most accomplished shooters, an exceptional coach and a dedicated mentor who inspired generations of aspiring sportspersons through his commitment to excellence. A renowned pistol shooter specialising in the 25-metre discipline, Rana brought immense glory to the country through his achievements on the international stage.

Recognising his extraordinary talent, he received the Arjuna Award in 1994 at the age of 18 and was later honoured with the prestigious Dronacharya Award for his outstanding contribution to coaching. Equally remarkable was his role as a mentor. Through his guidance and dedication, he nurtured several young talents, including Manu Bhaker, who went on to win two bronze medals at the Paris Olympics. His transition from champion shooter to successful coach reflected his deep commitment to Indian sport. Jaspal Rana's passing is an irreparable loss to the sporting fraternity. Though he is no longer with us, his achievements and contributions will continue to inspire future generations. The nation will remain forever indebted to this remarkable sports icon. May his family find strength during this difficult time. May his soul rest in peace.

RAMESH G. JETHWANI | BENGALURU

Europe’s drift into Trump’s detention logic

What is emerging in Europe is not a clean policy shift but a gradual reorganisation of how state power is distributed across space. The centre keeps legal language and institutional identity. The periphery carries operational burden



NILANTHA ILANGAMUWA

What is the most striking fact in policy implementation in most developed countries, which are developed largely by extracting resources from countries whose collapse was often externally shaped, and then channeling funds through backchannels into networks that can include armed actors, is that their real operating structure rarely matches the language they use in public.

Front-facing governance is built on carefully polished claims about rights, legality, and humanitarian duty. Back-end governance runs on pressure, leverage, trade-offs, and arrangements that would not survive public moral exposure unless rewritten in technical language. That gap is not accidental. It is structural. It is how modern state systems preserve internal legitimacy while running external coercion through distributed layers of responsibility.

Last week the European Union moved forward on what is presented as a major migration overhaul, including mechanisms that would allow deportation of rejected asylum seekers to “return hubs” outside its borders. This is not the first time such logic has appeared in Western governance. It is only the latest form of a longer pattern. Earlier phases used different tools. In security policy it was extraordinary rendition. In financial systems it was offshore architecture. In military interventions it was proxy enforcement. The pattern is always the same: move sensitive functions away from the centre, keep central language clean, and distribute execution into spaces where oversight is weaker and accountability is diluted. The European migration proposals sit inside that tradition, even if expressed through legal and administrative language rather than secrecy.

The idea of sending rejected asylum seekers into facilities outside EU territory is not described as punishment or exile in official terms. It is framed as “return management”. That phrase does a lot of work. It removes emotional weight. It removes the violence embedded in forced removal. It turns a human outcome into a logistical process. Once language is reduced to procedure, moral friction becomes easier to manage. That reduction is not neutral. It enables policy movement that would otherwise face stronger resistance.

There is a deeper issue underneath the debate about return hubs. It is the question of where legal responsibility sits when a state transfers individuals into systems it does not fully control. European legal order has spent decades building the principle that rights follow jurisdiction and jurisdiction follows effective control. That principle becomes unstable when control is outsourced. If a person is held outside EU territory under an arrangement initiated, funded, or coordinated by EU states, then the legal system enters a grey zone it has never fully resolved. The system does not break. It bends.

This bending is not new. The United Kingdom’s attempt to build an offshore asylum system in Rwanda exposed the same tension in a more direct way. The UK scheme reportedly cost well over £200 million in public spending before producing almost no operational transfers, collapsing under sustained legal challenge and judicial rejection.

It became a case where large financial commitment created political signalling, but not real deportation capacity. In practice, the system functioned more as deterrence narrative than working infrastructure.

That failure matters because it shows a recurring pattern: outsourcing migration enforcement does not remove legal constraint, it relocates it. Courts do not disappear when policy is externalised. They reappear at the point of transfer, questioning safety, fairness, and legality of removal. The result is often delay, blockage, or full suspension, even after major political and financial investment.

The European proposals now emerging operate in the shadow of that experience, yet they continue to assume that a more coordinated supranational framework will avoid similar outcomes. That assumption may not hold. Legal constraints are not national quirks. They are embedded in the European Convention on Human Rights and in the broader constitutional structure that binds member states. Externalisation does not remove those constraints. It shifts where they become active.



There is also a political dimension that cannot be ignored. Migration has become a central pressure point in domestic politics across Europe.

Public frustration is not only about numbers but about system failure. When deportation orders are issued but not carried out at scale, the authority of the system weakens in the eyes of voters. Governments respond by trying to close the gap between decision and outcome. External hubs are presented as one method of doing this. The goal is not only border control but credibility restoration.

The problem is that credibility in legal systems is not restored through enforcement alone. It depends on legitimacy of process. If enforcement is seen as bypassing safeguards, credibility can decline even as action increases. The system becomes more active but less trusted. That tension is already visible in debates around detention expansion and wider enforcement powers. Each new tool increases administrative reach but also increases legal and ethical resistance.

When states negotiate arrangements with third countries to host return facilities, they are not only moving people. They are moving legal exposure.

The host country becomes the site of detention, complaints, and conditions, while the initiating country keeps political responsibility without full legal visibility. This creates a structure where accountability is deliberately split. It is not absence of responsibility. It is fragmentation of it.

This logic is not without precedent in the darker parts of recent Western security practice, where distance was used as a tool of legal and moral insulation. In accounts of CIA extraordinary rendition and black site operations, as detailed in Ghost Plane: *The True Story of the CIA Rendition and Torture Program* by Stephen Grey and further analysed in *The Black Banners* by Ali H. Soufan, the same structural impulse appears. The point was not only control of individuals but control of visibility itself.

The more fragmented the system becomes, the harder it is to identify where harm is assessed and addressed. If a person experiences rights violations in an external facility, which court has authority, which inspectorate has access, which political body carries responsibility.

There is also a quiet shift in how enforcement is understood. It is no longer a simple choice between admission and exclusion. It is becoming a chain of administrative stages spread across multiple jurisdictions.

Entry control, asylum processing, appeal limits, removal decisions, external transfer, detention pending return. Each stage is separated and justified on its own terms. But the combined effect is a system that is harder to challenge as a whole because no single step appears decisive enough to contest.

What is emerging in Europe is not a clean policy shift but a gradual reorganisation of how state power is distributed across space. The centre keeps legal language and institutional identity. The periphery carries operational burden. Between them is a growing zone of uncertainty where governance increasingly operates, not only in migration policy but across areas where states try to balance internal legitimacy with external pressure.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

WHAT IS EMERGING IN EUROPE IS NOT A CLEAN POLICY SHIFT BUT A GRADUAL REORGANISATION OF HOW STATE POWER IS DISTRIBUTED ACROSS SPACE

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The Pioneer

Key achievements of Prime Minister Narendra Modi in 12 years of governance



VK BAHUGUNA

On May 26, 2014, Narendra Modi was sworn in as India’s Prime Minister after the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance swept the Lok Sabha elections. On May 10, 2026, he quietly crossed a historic threshold - 4,399 days in office - surpassing the 4,398-day tenure of Jawaharlal Nehru, India’s first Prime Minister. Winning three consecutive mandates, Modi expanded BJP’s state-level presence from 7 to 22 governments, covering 72 per cent of India’s landmass and 78 per cent of its population. Over these twelve years, his leadership has fundamentally reoriented India’s governance ethos, economic ambitions, and global standing, anchored by the guiding philosophy of “Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas” - together with all, development for all, trust of all.

The transformation of India’s economic architecture has been sweeping. The nominal GDP nearly doubled, climbing from ₹125.41 lakh crore to ₹345 lakh crore, placing India at approximately \$4.15 trillion and cementing its position as the world’s fifth-largest economy by nominal terms and third-largest by purchasing power parity. Per capita income rose from ₹86,647 to ₹2,19,575.

The 2017 introduction of the Goods and

Services Tax unified a fragmented indirect tax maze into a single “One Nation, One Tax” framework, eliminating cascading levies and widening the formal tax base. Demonetisation in 2016 targeted black money and counterfeit currency, accelerating the shift toward digital transactions. The Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code resolved stressed assets worth lakhs of crores. Foreign exchange reserves climbed to approximately \$670 billion. FDI inflows surged following liberalisation in defence, railways, and insurance. Make in India propelled manufacturing in electronics, solar energy, semiconductors, and pharmaceuticals. Startup India grew the entrepreneurial ecosystem from a few hundred ventures to over 3.3 lakh recognised startups. Defence exports, once a modest ₹1,900 crore, scaled to ₹23,000 crore - a testament to India’s growing strategic manufacturing capability.

Perhaps nowhere is the imprint of this era more visible than in India’s physical infrastructure. National highways expanded from 98,000 km to 1.46 lakh km under the Bharatmala scheme. The Gati Shakti National Master Plan brought multimodal connectivity planning under one integrated framework. Railways saw comprehensive modernisation - electrification, Vande Bharat trains, high-speed corridors, station redevelopment, and Dedicated Freight Corridors that improved logistics efficiency nationwide. Operational airports more than doubled from 74 to over 160, with the UDAN scheme democratising air travel



to smaller towns. Solar energy capacity leaped from a negligible 2.6 GW to over 110 GW, underpinned by the International Solar Alliance co-founded with France.

The welfare architecture constructed over this period is historically significant in both scale and intent. Direct Benefit Transfers minimised leakages, saving over ₹3 lakh crore that would otherwise have been lost to corruption. The Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana opened over 58 crore bank accounts, integrating women and rural populations into the formal financial system. The Swachh Bharat Mission oversaw the construction of over 12 crore household toilets, enabling India to declare itself Open Defecation Free. Over 10 crore LPG connections were provided to poor households under the Ujjwala Yojana, reducing indoor air pollution and easing the daily burden on women.

Ayushman Bharat (PM-JAY) extended health insurance coverage of ₹5 lakh per family to over

55 crore beneficiaries - one of the largest public health programmes in human history. Food security was assured for 80 crore people during and after COVID-19. PM-KISAN provided direct income support to farmers, while Skill India and Stand-Up India strengthened employment pathways and supported marginalised entrepreneurs including women and Scheduled Communities. One initiative that merits special mention is Hunar Haat - exhibitions at Pragati Maidan and venues across the country showcasing the craftsmanship of over 15 lakh Muslim artisans. For observers who have attended these over many years, the visible uplift of these communities represents a quiet but profound social achievement, one that ironically came despite these communities largely withholding their electoral support.

India’s digital leap has been globally recognised. The Unified Payments Interface grew from near-zero in 2016 to over 22 billion monthly transactions by 2026. The CoWIN platform enabled one of the world’s largest COVID-19 vaccination drives. Investments in semiconductor manufacturing, artificial intelligence, and cybersecurity have positioned India for the demands of the Fourth Industrial Revolution. On the world stage, Modi’s personal diplomacy elevated India’s stature considerably. The abrogation of Article 370 in August 2019 completed the constitutional integration of Jammu and Kashmir. Surgical strikes, the Balakot operation, and more recently Operation Sindoor signalled India’s willingness to act decisively

against cross-border terrorism. The successful evacuation of Indian citizens from conflict zones reinforced India’s soft power.

The abolition of Triple Talaq protected Muslim women from a regressive practice. Labour code consolidations streamlined decades of overlapping regulation. Transparent coal-block auctions generated substantial revenue, while anti-corruption measures and institutional accountability reforms restored credibility to public systems.

Looking Ahead

Challenges remain - unemployment concerns persist and growth has not been uniform across all regions and communities. Yet the foundational work of these twelve years is undeniable. India has moved perceptibly toward self-reliance, digital empowerment, and infrastructure modernity, with welfare genuinely reaching communities that were long bypassed. As India sets its sights on developed-nation status by 2047, the platform built in this era provides both the springboard and the proof of concept. The story of this tenure is ultimately one of bold structural reform fused with mass-scale human empowerment — a combination that has measurably altered India’s trajectory on the world stage.



NIKHIL ANAND

As Narendra Modi completes twelve years as Prime Minister, assessments of his tenure naturally crowd the public discourse. Most analysts examine economic reforms, infrastructure growth, foreign policy and national security. Yet one of the most consequential transformations of this period remains underexamined: a fundamental reimagining of what social justice means in India.

For most of independent India’s history, social justice was understood through a relatively narrow lens - reservations, representation and political participation. These were legitimate priorities in a society shaped by centuries of caste-based discrimination and exclusion. Over time, however, the discourse calcified into electoral arithmetic and identity mobilisation, often losing sight of the deeper question: were ordinary citizens actually living better lives? The Modi government has challenged that confinement. Its central proposition is that social justice cannot be measured by institutional representation alone. It must also be measured by access to housing, healthcare, education, economic opportunity and human dignity.

This philosophy is captured in the governing motto Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas - development for all, with all, trusted by all and driven by all. Under this framework, development itself becomes a vehicle for social transformation. Modi’s own rise carries symbolic weight within this story. He became the first Prime Minister from an Other Backward Class background to win repeated national mandates on the strength of governance rather than dynasty or elite patronage. His ascent signalled a democratisation of political power in a country where leadership had historically concentrated within narrow social circles. But symbolism alone does not define a legacy - policy does.

On representation, successive Union Councils of Ministers under Modi have included significant participation from Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, OBC communities and women, earning recognition as among the most socially diverse cabinets in independent India’s history. On substantive reform, perhaps the single most consequential intervention was extending 27 percent OBC reservation to the All India Quota in medical admissions through NEET. For decades, a glaring inconsistency existed: OBC students competed for these seats without the reservation benefits available in state institutions. Correcting this anomaly was widely regarded as the most significant pro-OBC policy step since the Mandal Commission’s implementation.

Alongside this, granting constitutional status to the National Commission for Backward Classes addressed a long-standing demand from backward-class organisations, embedding institutional protection into the constitutional framework itself. The Cabinet’s more recent endorsement of caste enumeration reflects an acknowledgment that effective policymaking requires clearer data on India’s social realities. The government has also invested in recognising the intellectual and moral heritage of India’s social justice movement. Conferring the Bharat Ratna on Karpoori Thakur - a towering figure for backward-class communities - carried deep resonance across generations. Similarly, the institutionalisation of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar’s legacy, through the development of memorial sites and the observance of Constitution Day, has reinforced public consciousness of the foundational role Ambedkar played in Indian democracy. These are not merely ceremonial gestures; they connect contemporary governance to the long tradition of social justice thinking in India.

The government also expanded affirmative action beyond its traditional categories. The introduction of 10 percent reservation for Economically Weaker Sections within the general category formally recognised economic deprivation as an independent basis for affirmative action - the first time such a principle was codified in India’s policy framework. Crucially, this was designed without disturbing existing protections for SC, ST and OBC communities. The passage of Women’s Reservation legislation, guaranteeing one-third of seats in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, represents another structural commitment to inclusive political participation.

Perhaps the most practically transformative initiative of the Modi years has been the shift to beneficiary-centric welfare delivery. Historically, social welfare programmes haemorrhaged resources through leakages, middlemen and patronage networks. The convergence of Jan Dhan bank accounts, Aadhaar-based authentication and Direct Benefit Transfers fundamentally disrupted that model. Schemes including Ujjwala Yojana, Ayushman Bharat, PM Awas Yojana, Swachh Bharat Mission and Jal Jeevan Mission have extended basic capabilities - clean cooking fuel, health insurance, housing, sanitation and piped water - to tens of millions of previously excluded citizens. The principle driving these programmes is universality: delivery based on need, not political affiliation.

The cumulative impact on human welfare has been significant. Hundreds of millions of Indians have seen measurable improvements across multidimensional poverty indicators over the past decade. Poverty is not only a deficit of income - it is a denial of security, dignity and opportunity. When a family gains a permanent home, healthcare coverage or access to a bank account for the first time, those are social justice achievements as much as economic ones. During the COVID-19 pandemic, the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana provided free food grains to nearly 800 million people, demonstrating the state’s capacity to function as a guarantor of basic security in a national crisis.

Underlying all of this is a broader ideological shift - from identity politics to aspirational politics. The traditional social justice framework asked who holds power. The Modi framework adds a further question: do young Indians have access to education, skills, healthcare and upward mobility regardless of background? Development, in this vision, becomes the most powerful instrument of social transformation.

India’s social justice tradition has been shaped by towering figures - Ambedkar, who built its constitutional foundations; Karpoori Thakur, who gave voice to backward communities; B.P. Mandal, who reshaped the politics of representation. What the Modi years have attempted is a synthesis: integrating representation, welfare delivery, economic empowerment and cultural confidence into a single governance framework. Whether that integration fully succeeds remains for history to judge - but the ambition to move social justice from slogan to nation-building principle marks a genuine shift in India’s political imagination.



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Order Order

Court acquits prison inmate accused of attacking officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A sessions court has acquitted a 25-year-old jail inmate accused of assaulting officials inside the Thane Central Prison in 2017, ruling that the prosecution has failed to prove the charges beyond a reasonable doubt.

Additional Sessions Judge GT Pawar, in a judgment delivered on June 11, acquitted Arman Nafis Khan of offences under sections 353 (Assault on a public servant), 332 (Causing hurt to deter a public servant from duty) and 506 (Criminal intimidation) of the Indian Penal Code.

According to the prosecution, Khan had attacked prison officer Sambhaji Pise and two other personnel with a metal strip on March 2, 2017, in a high-security barrack of Thane Central Prison.



The judge pointed out several shortcomings in the prosecution's case, noting that although the incident allegedly occurred inside the prison and several inmates were present, crucial evidence was not produced.

"The injuries caused to the accused were not properly explained by the prison authority," the court stated, while observing that the "defence of the accused that he was beaten up by the informant and others, and to avoid action against them, this report was lodged, cannot be ruled out."

UP court summons two cops in Dalit assault case probe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Sultanpur (UP)

A special SC/ST court here has summoned two police officers to face trial for allegedly manipulating the probe into a Dalit atrocity, assault and attempted culpable homicide case.

Special Judge (SC/ST Act) Rakesh Pandey took serious note of the alleged irregularities in the probe and issued summons against former Amethi Additional Superintendent of Police Harendra Kumar and Circle Officer Akhilesh Verma.

The court also directed that a copy of the order be sent to the Principal Secretary (Home) and Director General of Police for initiating departmental action.

Government counsel Sushil Upadhyay said the court, while passing the order on Friday, termed the investigation process "deplorable".

The court observed that charge sheets against five named accused were submitted multiple times by different investigating officers, but the Kumar repeatedly returned the charge sheets and interfered in the investigation.

The court noted that the name of accused Vikram Singh was dropped from the case and termed it an attempt to derail justice and protect the main accused through misuse of official position and interference in a fair investigation.

SC refers defamation dispute involving two Karnataka officers to mediation, stays proceedings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has referred the long-running defamation dispute between Karnataka cadre IAS officer Rohini Sindhuri and IPS officer D Roopa Moudgil to mediation, saying that the prolonged legal battle was damaging the careers of both senior civil servants.

A bench comprising Justices Satish Chandra Sharma and Sanjeev Sachdeva on Friday appointed former Supreme Court judge Kurian Joseph as sole mediator to facilitate an amicable settlement between the officers.

"Both of them are destroying each other's careers," Justice Sharma remarked during the hearing.

Passing the order, the bench said it was of the view that the dispute could be resolved through mediation rather than continued litigation.

"In the present case, this Court is of the opinion that the matter can be resolved by way of mediation.



"Justice Joseph, retired Supreme Court Judge, is appointed as the mediator. The parties shall appear before Justice Joseph.

"By way of interim relief, further proceedings in respect of both the cases between the parties shall remain stayed," the court



A delicate balance: 12 years of Government-judiciary relations under NDA



The 12-year relationship between the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government and the judiciary has been a story of deep tension mixed with quiet cooperation.

While both sides have worked together to modernize courts, their basic disagreement over power has created an uneasy and often difficult relationship.

The relationship has been most successful in modernizing the administrative side of justice. Instead of fighting over laws, the government and the judiciary have cooperated closely on technology. Under Phases II and III of the e-Courts Project, the government provided the necessary funds to digitize thousands of courtrooms and rural district courts.

This joint effort established virtual courts for minor offenses, connected major prisons to courtrooms via video links, and introduced live-streaming for key constitutional cases, making the legal system much more transparent. Despite their smooth cooperation on technology, the two institutions have locked horns deeply over who gets to choose higher court judges. This remains the biggest source of anger and distrust.

Early in its term, the government tried to end the judge-led "Collegium system" by introducing the National Judicial Appointments Commission (NJAC) to give elected leaders a say in appointments.

The Supreme Court struck this



down in 2015, declaring that choosing judges without executive interference is vital to its independence.

Since it cannot legally dismantle the Collegium, the government has used administrative delays to show its displeasure. It frequently sits on files, delaying the appointment of recommended judges for months or years.

The executive has also regularly used "selective clearing"-approving some names from a list while ignoring others, particularly candidates who have openly criticized government policies in the past.

The tension between the executive's majoritarian mandates and the judiciary's role as a constitutional check has triggered several other major clashes.

The government has heavily utilized strict special laws like the PMLA (money laundering law) and UAPA (anti-terror law) against political opponents and activists.

Because these laws make getting bail nearly impossible, the judiciary has stepped in. Benches have repeatedly warned that keeping people in jail indefinitely without a trial turns the investigation into a punishment, directly pushing back against aggressive executive enforcement.

The judiciary has dealt major political blows to the government.

ic growth and infrastructure, the judiciary has often acted as a brake.

The courts have repeatedly penalized illegal mining operations, questioned the dilution of environmental impact assessments, and pulled up state agencies for failing to enforce ecological laws, causing a direct conflict with the executive's developmental agenda.

The disagreement between the government and the courts has moved out of the courtrooms and into the public eye. Both sides are openly arguing about who has the final say over the country's laws.

High-ranking leaders-including former Vice President and former Law Ministers - have publicly attacked a famous 1973 court ruling (the Kesavananda Bharati case). They argue that because the public elects the government, Parliament should have the supreme power to change any law. They feel that judges should not be allowed to block changes made by elected politicians.

The judiciary has pushed back strongly. They explained that the Constitution has a permanent core-called the "Basic Structure"-that protects the citizens' fundamental rights. One of the Chief Justices called this core the country's "North Star" (a permanent guide). He stated that just because a government wins an election, it does not give it the right to destroy the core protections of the Constitution.

Despite the regular friction, the relationship has not been entirely stuck in a deadlock. On several complex social and reservation policies, the executive and judiciary have managed to find a constructive, albeit delicate, balance.

For instance, the Supreme Court upheld the government's 10 per cent quota for the Economically Weaker Sections (EWS) and paved

a legal pathway for the sub-classification of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes.

These moments demonstrate that when policies target deep social corrections without altering the framework of the Constitution, the court has willingly partnered with the executive's legislative goals. While recent leadership on both sides has helped keep communication channels open, the underlying institutional rivalry remains entirely unresolved.

Ultimately, the 12-year legacy of the NDA government's relationship with the judiciary shows that India's democracy is experiencing a protracted tug-of-war: the executive seeks maximum space to implement its political mandate, while the judiciary fights to guard its role as the ultimate constitutional check.

Yet, while these grand institutional battles capture the headlines, the daily reality of the justice system remains deeply troubled. Grand digital platforms and rewritten penal codes are empty victories if the foundational pyramid is falling apart. According to real-time tracking from the National Judicial Data Grid (NJDG), India's backlogs have crossed a staggering 55 million pending cases. This backlog, combined with a severe shortage of trial judges, means that everyday citizens are the ones who suffer the most and pay the price for this stubborn fight between the government and the courts.

True judicial reform requires both sides to step back from their battle for supremacy and work together to build a functional, well-staffed, and accessible grassroots legal system. Until that happens, the modernization of Indian justice will remain incomplete.

Writer is a journalist, covering legal affairs

Unauthorised absence by RBI official misconduct, says HC; upholds his removal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Unauthorised absence from work by a Reserve Bank of India (RBI) official would be detrimental to the public interest and amount to grave misconduct, the Bombay High Court has said, refusing relief to an employee who was removed from service.

The petitioner, Animesh Bakuli, was a senior assistant with the RBI and would undoubtedly be occupying a responsible post from which he was unauthorisedly absent for a long period, a bench of Justices RI Chagla and Advait Sethna noted in

the order passed on June 10.

"Such unauthorised absence would undoubtedly be detrimental to the public interest and a grave misconduct which would warrant dismissal from service," the court said.

Dismissing Bakuli's plea, it said the RBI's decision compulsorily retiring him from service does not suffer from any infirmity.

Bakuli had sought that the HC quash the RBI's February 2023 order compulsorily retiring him from service on the ground of unauthorised absence. He also demanded a direction to the Reserve Bank to disburse payment and other



allowances blocked it since December 2020 without notice.

The petitioner was employed with the RBI from 2013 and was designated as a senior assistant since January 2018.

Bakuli had on several occasions sought that the RBI transfer him to Kolkata so that he could live with his parents. The Reserve Bank rejected his requests.

From March 2020, Bakuli

remained absent from his duties without permission from his superiors. The RBI sent repeated communications to Bakuli directing him to either report back to duty or submit a leave application supported by a medical certificate. However, he did not respond.

The RBI then issued him a show-cause notice and initiated an enquiry against him for committing breach and misconduct of rules and regulations governing the apex bank.

As per the RBI, Bakuli failed to reply to the notice and also did not appear for the enquiry meetings to present his arguments. Pursuant to this, the final order imposing

a penalty of compulsory retirement was passed against him.

As per the petitioner, he left Mumbai for Kolkata to be with his parents during the COVID-19 pandemic and hence could not report to work.

In his plea, Bakuli claimed the decision was harsh and that the enquiry violated the principles of natural justice as he was not given a chance to put forth his case.

The bench, however, noted that there has been no such violation as several opportunities were given to him to remain present during the disciplinary proceedings.

Democracy under threat in Andhra as YSRCP social media pages face restrictions: Jagan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

YSRCP supremo YS Jagan Mohan Reddy on Sunday alleged that democracy and freedom of expression were "under threat" in Andhra Pradesh under Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu-led government after the party's official Facebook page became allegedly inaccessible.

TDP spokesperson Neelayapalem Vijay Kumar rejected Jagan's allegations and contended that the restriction of YSRCP's Facebook page was a legal consequence of violating cyber laws rather than an attempt to curb free speech.

In a post on 'X', Jagan said, "This is not just an attack on YSRCP; it is an attack on democratic values and freedom of



expression. We only reveal facts, expose the government's failures and corrupt practices, and bring to light issues that affect the people."

The opposition leader alleged that the restriction on the party's Facebook page followed the earlier takedown of YSRCP's official Instagram handle and reflected a broader attempt to suppress opposition voices.

According to Jagan, silencing an opposition party's official social media platforms for speaking the truth sets a dangerous precedent and was contrary to democratic principles. The former chief minister alleged that a pattern of suppression was emerging in the state, ranging from police cases against those questioning the government to restrictions on critical content online.

He claimed that individuals raising concerns over expenditure related to Amaravati capital development, alleged irregularities in the DSC process, TTD ghee tenders and other matters of public importance were facing action. The former CM also alleged that evidence relating to corruption and government failures was being suppressed through intimidation and censorship.

The opposition leader asserted that YSRCP would challenge the restrictions through all available legal and constitutional avenues.

He maintained that no intimidation, censorship or alleged misuse of institutions could silence the voice of the people or prevent the party from holding those in power accountable.

Ex-RCom official Gautam Doshi sent to five-day ED custody in ₹40,000 crore money laundering probe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Saturday sent former Reliance Communications (RCom) senior executive Gautam Bhailal Doshi to five days of Enforcement Directorate custody in a money laundering case linked to alleged diversion of loan funds worth over ₹40,000 crore.

Special Judge Gaurav Rao was hearing the agency's plea seeking Doshi's custody for 14 days.

Doshi was produced at the judge's residence at around 8.15 am after he was arrested and taken to Delhi from

diversion and layering of loan funds.

After hearing arguments from both sides, the court remanded Doshi to ED custody till June 18.

According to the ED, the investigation has revealed a fund trail involving diversion of loan funds from Reliance ADA Group entities to foreign remittances, offshore companies and foreign bank accounts.

The agency alleged that loans availed from banks were not utilised for their intended purposes and were instead invested in mutual funds and transferred to group companies.



The ED told the court that Doshi occupied a position of "substantial authority and control" within the Reliance ADA Group and was closely associated with its financial,

corporate and offshore operations.

It alleged that Doshi functioned as one of the Group Managing Directors of the Reliance ADA Group, was a director of Reliance Telecom Ltd during the relevant period and also served as a member of its audit committee.

The probe agency further claimed that key information relating to financial operations was regularly escalated to Doshi and functioned under his supervision.

"The investigation so far has established a fund trail showing diversion of loan funds from RAAG to foreign remittances, foreign banks

and offshore companies. The funds so availed from certain banks were not utilised for the intended purpose," the court said.

Seeking his custody, the ED said Doshi needs to be confronted with seized emails, electronic records, financial documents and witness statements to identify the ultimate beneficiaries of the alleged proceeds of crime and trace domestic as well as overseas assets.

The defence opposed the ED's remand plea, arguing that no justifiable grounds existed either for Doshi's arrest or for granting custodial remand.

Senior defence counsel submitted that Doshi had cooperated throughout the investigation and had appeared before the agency after recording of his statement under Section 50 of the PMLA on January 27 this year.

The defence also cited Doshi's advanced age — around 74 years — and his medical ailments while opposing the ED's demand for 14-day custody.

The court, while allowing ED remand for five days, directed the agency to make necessary arrangements concerning the accused's medical condition.

FROM THE WORLD

NEPAL

2 Indians held in Nepal drug case

Two Indian nationals were among three people arrested in Nepal for allegedly possessing a huge quantity of narcotic drugs, police said. The Nepal police arrested the Indian nationals identified as Ahmad Lahn, 32, and Mohamad Saddam, 33, hailing from Sitamarhi district, Bihar, on Saturday.

A Nepalese citizen, Jitendra Paswan, was also arrested by the police. The arrests were made after police opened fire on the suspects when they did not stop at a security check, officials said. Around 30,000 capsules of Tramadol, a kind of drug used as a painkiller and for intoxication, were recovered from the suspects, said officials. A car and a motorbike used by the suspects, and five mobile sets were also seized by the authorities. (PTI)

PAKISTAN

7 killed in NW Pakistan rains

Seven people, including two children, were killed and 33 injured in rain-related incidents in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province in northwest Pakistan in the past 24 hours, the disaster management officials said on Sunday. Heavy rains, strong winds and lightning triggered roof and wall collapses killed four men, two children, and one woman in Bannu, Shangla and Mansehra districts, the Provincial Disaster Management Authority (PDMA) said. At least 33 people sustained injuries, according to the PDMA report. In a related development, the PDMA also warned of the risk of Glacial Lake Outburst Floods (GLOFs) in the upper regions of the province, saying rising temperatures and ongoing rainfall had accelerated glacier melting and increased the likelihood of flash floods. Residents have been advised to avoid river banks, seasonal streams and locations with strong water currents, it said. (PTI)

India's potential is amazing, need holistic perspective: Embraer

MANOJ RAMMOHAN
■ Sao Paulo

India's potential is amazing and there is a need to work with a holistic perspective, Embraer Commercial Aviation CEO Arjan Meijer has said as the Brazilian aerospace major pursues opportunities in the civilian and defence aircraft segments. Embraer is betting big on India and in January this year, announced a strategic collaboration with the Adani Group that aims to set up a regional aircraft manufacturing facility in India. Besides, the company is pitching its KC-390 Millennium aircraft for the Indian Air Force's Medium



Transport Aircraft (MTA) programme. In a brief interaction with PTI at Embraer's headquarters in Sao Jose dos Campos in Sao Paulo, Brazil, Meijer said the company is focused not only on commercial but also on the defence areas in India. "India is the biggest market around the world, with well over a billion people, with a travel propensity which is very low. (PTI)

UK forces intercept Russian shadow fleet vessel in English Channel

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

British armed forces intercepted a sanctioned Russian shadow fleet oil tanker in the English Channel on Sunday morning in the first UK-led operation of its kind.

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer confirmed that the vessel SMYRTOS was boarded by Royal Marine Commandos and specially trained law enforcement officers from the National Crime Agency (NCA). The military operation, which lasted six hours, was supported with aircraft from the Maritime Air Group - Chinooks, Merlin Mk4 and Wildcat - a Royal Air Force (RAF) P-8 aircraft, as well as



HMS Sutherland and HMS Ledbury. "This operation delivers yet another blow to Russia and reminds those fuelling (Russian President Vladimir) Putin's war in Ukraine that they cannot

research, and engineering talent has made it one of the world's most dynamic innovation hubs.

According to Macron, the country's ability to produce more than one million engineers annually demonstrates its significant contribution to global technological development.

Underscoring India's strategic importance in the innovation ecosystem, Macron said the global conversation has shifted from questioning India's innovative capacity to identifying partners willing to collaborate with the country on future technologies. The French President also expressed pride in hosting the first international edition of Bharat Innovates, describing the event as a

valuable platform for fostering connections between Indian entrepreneurs, researchers, startups, investors, and French institutions.

During his address, Macron welcomed Prime Minister Modi and congratulated him on becoming India's longest-serving elected Prime Minister. He praised Modi's leadership and described his tenure as a reflection of both his commitment to national development and India's growing global stature.

Focusing on artificial intelligence, Macron stressed that India and France share a common vision of open, inclusive, and collaborative technological progress.

He said both nations support responsible AI devel-



PM Narendra Modi with French President Emmanuel Macron and others during the inauguration of the 'Bharat Innovates' event in Nice, France PTI

opment that promotes innovation while remaining accessible and beneficial to society. The French leader

also warned against emerging trends that seek to limit access to advanced technologies, emphasizing the impor-

As Trump turns 80 with showstopping spectacle of cage fights at White House, big issues loom

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Washington

President Donald Trump celebrates turning 80 on Sunday with a showstopping birthday spectacle that once would have seemed unfathomable: a cage-fighting show on the storied South Lawn of the White House.

This week, the hard realities of the office have threatened to overshadow the ostentatious UFC mixed martial arts extravaganza, where combatants sealed inside a wire-mesh octagon try to punch, kick, chop and pummel each other into submission. Trump has found himself boxed into an unpopular and costly war he helped start in Iran. An agreement to end the conflict could be close, but the crucial details are still to be negotiated. Meanwhile, about a mile from



Trump's birthday bash, crews pried the president's name off the Kennedy Center after a judge ruled naming it after Trump had gone too far.

Regardless, the president will walk out of the White House and be surrounded by Cabinet leaders, top administration officials, Republican lawmakers and

Nice from June 14 to 16.

The conclave has attracted startups, venture capital firms, policymakers, academic institutions, and industry leaders from India, France, and several other countries.

More than 120 Indian deep-tech startups and over 15 leading higher education and research institutions are participating in the event.

Discussions at the summit are centered on key sectors including artificial intelligence, semiconductors, advanced computing, biotechnology, healthcare, defence technologies, space innovation, and climate-focused solutions, reflecting the growing importance of technology-driven partnerships between India and France.

4,000-plus spectators screaming themselves hoarse in a temporary arena under "The Claw," a spaceship-like metal arch fitted with lighting, sound equipment and large screens. Thousands more will be watching on big screens from the nearby Ellipse.

"This event is a one of one event, incredible event. I love it," said UFC chief Dana White, a close friend of the president, during a Friday night hype session at the Lincoln Memorial where pairs of fighters shoved and scuffled for the cameras under the stoic gaze of Honest Abe's marble likeness. The president has sought to tie Sunday's event — which features seven fights running past midnight - to larger, months-long celebrations of the 250th anniversary of the signing of the Declaration of Independence.

Thousands gather in Geneva to protest G7 as Trump, other leaders hold summit in nearby France

JAMEY KEATEN ■ Geneva

Thousands of demonstrators converged Sunday to show their discontent against the G7 group of rich countries, with US President Donald Trump and counterparts set to hold a summit starting a day later in nearby France. Environmentalists and feminists joined foes of imperialism, defenders of independent media, supporters of Palestinian rights and others in a lakeside park in Geneva for a march across town. A boat whose sail read "No G7" floated by, as sunbathers and swimmers basked under blue skies.

Swiss and French authori-



ties have deployed thousands of police to provide security for the three-day summit starting Monday in the resort

town of Evian-les-Bains, France. The leaders are set to discuss issues including the Middle East, Ukraine and

global economic imbalances.

Authorities have blocked off roads, banned unauthorised gatherings and pledged financial support for businesses who could be hit by unrest. Scores of businesses and shops have boarded up their storefronts with wooden panels as a precaution - leery of upheaval that left a trail of damage in Geneva during a similar summit in Evian in 2003. Only seven of the 35 roadway border crossings will remain open.

Demonstrators have been gathering for days in advance of Sunday's march in Geneva, the largest city in the area and designated gathering spot for activists who oppose the

G7. A flotilla of around 20 boats appeared on Lake Geneva off the coast of Evian on Saturday, displaying anti-G7 and pro-Palestinian banners. Some 20 protesters were detained on Friday evening, according to Swiss media reports.

Earlier, between 100 and 150 people had gathered in Geneva for a protest bicycle ride, slowing down traffic and chanting anti-G7 and pro-Palestinian slogans, public broadcaster RTS reported. Local resident Robin Hedz lamented the "mess" and expressed bafflement about the "wood-wall everywhere," while acknowledging the memories of the

trail of damaged property at the summit over 20 years ago. France will deploy more than 13,000 police and gendarmie officers to ensure security in the summit area just across the border. Over 800 French border control officers will be active, up from about 60 normally.

French gendarmes buzzed around in motorboats off the coast of Evian on Saturday, and one officer hoisted up a bulky drone-interception device in a display of the security measures being rolled out for the summit.

Protests are nothing new around such elite gatherings. This time, activists want to demonstrate frustration with

Trump's leadership on issues as diverse as tariffs, the war in Iran and the climate, or even highlight his past ties to convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein. "We are very afraid of the policy and the politics of Mr. Trump and also of the other leaders of the G7, because they are fighting, making war all over the place," said Francoise Nyffeler, spokesperson for the NoG7 coalition, which has organised the demonstration and march on Sunday.

"The planet is in danger and we are very scared about it and we want to protest and say that the people of the world are against their policies," she added. (AP)

Palestinian death toll in Gaza tops 73,000: Officials

WAFAA SHURAFSA/SAMY MAGDY
■ Deir al-Balah

Gaza's Health Ministry says the Palestinian death toll from the Israel-Hamas war has surpassed 73,000.

The updated toll on Sunday came as Israel has continued to strike despite a fragile ceasefire deal reached in October. Confirmation came from Zaher al-Waheidi, head of the ministry's records department, and Hamza Salem from the ministry's public relations department. The total number of deaths since the beginning of the war is now 73,001. On Sunday, the ministry said, there were five deaths: two in the southern city of Khan Younis and one in central Gaza, in addition to two who died of earlier wounds.

Over 1,73,200 people have been wounded since the start of the war, which was ignited by the Hamas-led October 7, 2023 attack into Israel. That attack killed some 1,200 people and



took 251 others hostage. An Israeli strike on Saturday evening killed two Palestinians in Khan Younis. The casualties were taken to Nasser hospital, according to the Palestinian Red Crescent Society.

The Israeli military did not immediately respond to a request for comment. The health ministry, part of the Hamas-led government, is staffed by medical professionals and maintains detailed records viewed as generally reliable by

United Nations agencies and independent experts. It does not say how many of those killed were civilians or militants. It says women and children make up around half of all fatalities.

Israel says it tries to avoid harming civilians and blames their deaths on Hamas because the militants operate in densely populated areas.

It says it is carrying out strikes against militants who pose a threat, and in response to ceasefire violations, including occasional attacks. The US-brokered ceasefire deal reached in October ended full-scale military operations and led to the return of all the remaining hostages.

But other elements of the deal have stalled as Hamas has refused to disarm and Israeli troops have advanced, rather than withdrawn, since the deal was reached. Both sides accuse the other of violating the agreement but say it is still in effect. Five Israeli soldiers have been killed since the ceasefire. (AP)

Italy's Meloni faces far-right dilemma as Il Generale Vannacci rises

GIADA ZAMPANO ■ Rome

In a packed auditorium steps from the Vatican, Roberto Vannacci - the former Italian army general known to supporters as "Il Generale" - is rallying followers of his fledgling party, casting himself as an outsider while reshaping Italy's right and challenging Premier Giorgia Meloni.

Vannacci's fast-rising "Futuro Nazionale" party is injecting new uncertainty into the conservative bloc that has underpinned Meloni's government, exposing tensions ahead of the 2027 general election.

The question, analysts say, is no longer whether Vannacci will influence the vote, but whether Meloni can contain, co-opt or outmanoeuvre a challenger carving out political space to her right. The emergence of a rival on Meloni's right could also test the stability of her government and threaten the more moderate, pro-European approach the premier has so far adopted in office. Vannacci's rise comes as far-right and nationalist parties gain ground across Europe, reshaping the political landscape and focusing on polarising issues like migration and security.

"With us, Italy will once again be the home of Italians," Vannacci said at his party's founding assembly this weekend in Rome, "Everyone must feel safe in their own home."



He proudly described his core lawmakers as the "dirty dozen," stressing his outsider role. Vannacci, 57, emerged politically with his 2023 self-published book "Il mondo al contrario" (The World Upside Down), which drew controversy for harsh attacks on LGBTQ+ people, migrants and minorities.

He entered politics a year later with Matteo Salvini's anti-migration League, winning more than 530,000 preferences in European Parliament elections. He left the League in February to launch his Futuro Nazionale, a break Salvini called a "betrayal." Since then, Vannacci has consolidated support. The party says it has surpassed 100,000 members and now has eight deputies, including defectors from the League and centrist Forza Italia, underscoring unease within Meloni's coalition.

He rejects the traditional "far-right" label, calling his movement the "real right," and has accused Meloni of failing to turn shared priorities into policies. (AP)

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NEW DELHI | MONDAY | JUNE 15, 2026

BUSINESS13

More firms to make memory chips in India: Vaishnaw

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

New companies are likely to invest in India to manufacture memory chips while existing investors will scale up production to address the demand-supply gap in the segment, Union minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said in an interview to PTI.

Strong demand for memory (data storage) cards and advanced chips has tightened global supplies and supported higher prices in past quarters, and manufacturers have been sprucing up investments and production capacities to meet market requirements worldwide. The higher memory chip prices have, in turn, led to a rise in production costs for a range of electronic products, including smartphones and laptops.

"Definitely, a lot more invest-

ment is coming in the memory manufacturing units, and that is because for the first time in the way the semiconductor industry has grown at such a rapid pace, for the first time we are seeing a huge shortage of certain components which are required in the AI data centres, the high bandwidth memory chips," Vaishnaw said.

Data centre investments in India are expected to cross USD 200 billion soon, which may need billions of gigabytes of storage capacity.

The minister said there is a global phenomenon of supply-demand imbalance, which is now getting filled up by setting many more units.

"For example, there are the high bandwidth memory chips, which are manufactured by Micron. They are the first plant to start commercial production on February 28th this year.

This is the second plant which started commercial manufacturing on March 31st. These are the steps which have started giving results. There is a

serious supply-demand mismatch in the case of memory," he said.

When asked if there will be new investments in the memory chip segment or only existing players have plans to ramp up production, Vaishnaw said, "Looks like both might happen".

He said the India Semicon Mission 1.0 could get about 48 startups to work on the tech products.

"In ISM 2.0, that will be the topmost priority, design will be the topmost priority. The second biggest priority will be machines, which are used in the manufacturing of semiconductors. We will seriously be looking at getting the equipment manufacturers to come to India for designing the equipment as well as manufacturing the equipment," Vaishnaw said.

The minister said that after

decades of effort, India has been able to attract chip makers to the country under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's regime, as the India Semicon Mission 1.0 programme sets the foundation for a robust domestic semiconductor industry.

He said that work is in advance stage for ISM 2.0, under which chip design will be a topmost priority. The minister said the government will also look at the indigenous production of complex chemicals and gases that are used for manufacturing chips.

"Of course, we will be adding many more fabs (chip manufacturing plants) and ATMP (chip packaging) units. We will be carrying forward the progress we made in talent development in the first version of the semiconductor mission," Vaishnaw said.

CineNow to shortly close ₹1,350 cr fund to finance films

CineNow Ltd, a British Virgin Islands-registered company, is in the process of closing a ₹1,350 crore fund with commitments from overseas investors and family offices to finance films in India.

Most of the commitments have come for this closed-ended fund with a tenure of 6 years, CineNow founder director Rohit Dalmia said.

"CineNow is building a new category at the intersection of finance, entertainment and technology by transforming film intellectual property (IP) into a structured, investable asset. At its core is a Secured Participation Fund that provides exposure to a curated slate of films rather than a single title, with capital backed by enforceable rights across OTT, satellite, music and ancillary revenues," he said. It is going to create a platform where global capital and creative opportunity can converge within a disciplined and professionally managed environment, he said.

The firm has on-boarded the Oscar-winning sound designer Resul Pookutty as a founding member of the strategic council, apart from Abhay Sinha.

"Indian cinema IP needs a structured, multi-stage financial approach that ensures sustained value and leverage. CineNow's model disrupts traditional methods by offering slate-based portfolios, staged capital deployment, and comprehensive value-timed exits," he said.

CineNow is also pioneering the application of tokenisation within the entertainment sector, introducing a technology-led framework that enhances liquidity, transparency, and accessibility. (PTI)

Bio-energy emerging as key pillar of green growth strategy: TPCI

Bio-energy is emerging as a key pillar of India's green growth strategy and is set to play a crucial role in the country's energy transition, Trade Promotion Council of India (TPCI) said on Sunday.

The council, on June 12, gathered policymakers, diplomats, industry leaders, energy experts, innovators, and stakeholders from across the bio-energy ecosystem to deliberate on strategies for accelerating India's transition towards sustainable and energy-secure growth.

It said that the council has constituted a Bio-Energy Committee to bring together stakeholders across the sector, facilitate dialogue on policy and regulatory reforms, and recommend frameworks to accelerate adoption and unlock investment potential.

"Our goal is to strengthen India's bio-energy ecosystem and align industry priorities with our national climate commitments, including the pledge to achieve net-zero emissions. Now is the time. Collaboration will be the key. Government, industry, and academia must work together to ensure innovation, affordability, and scalability," TPCI Chairman Mohit Singla said.

He said that huge opportunities are there in the bio-energy sector, and it will help reduce dependence on fossil fuels while addressing waste management challenges.

From bio-CNG and ethanol blending to biomass power generation, this sector can significantly strengthen India's clean energy mix, create rural employment and empower farmers, Singla said.

"Bio-energy is not merely an alternative fuel source; it is a strategic pillar of India's green growth story, poised to become a cornerstone of our energy transition. Energy security, sustainability, climate resilience, and economic growth are no longer separate conversations. They are deeply interconnected," he added. (PTI)

In most aggressive phase of India expansion, here for long-term wins: Amazon India head

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Amazon is in the midst of its "most aggressive phase of expansion" in India yet, country head Samir Kumar has said, adding that the ecommerce giant is firmly focused on playing the long game for market and customer wins.

The comment from Amazon India's top honcho comes against the backdrop of the company's recently announced \$35 billion investment by 2030 - building on USD 40 billion already invested — to support business expansion, AI-driven digitisation, exports and job creation.

"If you look at our investments, we are one of the largest investments in India...\$35 billion over the next five years, \$80 billion of exports enablement, continuing to invest in Amazon Now and speed with 100 cities and 1,000 micro fulfillment

centres, so we are in the most aggressive phase of expansion in India yet, we are here to play a long-term and win in India," Kumar said.

Brushing aside concerns over market complexities and rising competitive intensity, Kumar emphasised the company's singular focus on enhancing consumer experience; he added that Amazon's leadership remains fully aligned and committed to this goal.

"I continue to focus on building the right experience for our Indian consumers, and as far as I know, and I spend time with my senior leaders, they are very much committed to that," Kumar said.

Kumar emphasised that Amazon is building for the long term and remains committed to sustained investments in India.

"We believe that we are building for the long run, and we continue to invest in India

in a big way, and for the long run as well," he said.

Asked about regulatory scrutiny of e-commerce and digital consumer platforms in India, Kumar said Amazon's approach here is consistent with its global operations, with the company's primary focus on ensuring compliance with local laws and regulations.

"We have regulatory compliance around the world, and we run a compliant business around the world, so regulatory pressure or regulatory challenges in India are no different from challenges around the world, and for me it's making sure we are running a compliant business in India is utmost important, and we are doing that," he said.

Amazon has built a diversified presence in India spanning ecommerce, digital payments, cloud computing, entertainment streaming, devices, logistics and seller services.

FSSAI issues notices to 8 food companies for misleading health claims on packaging, labels

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) on Sunday issued notices to eight food business operators for using misleading brand names, trade names and product claims in violation of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006.

The companies served notices include Emami Healthy & Tasty, Health Aid, Troovy, The Healthy Factory, Healthy Master, Healthy Choice, Plan B and Neuherbs.

The regulator announced the notices through its official social media handles.

Among the prominent names flagged is Emami Healthy & Tasty, the cooking oils arm of the Kolkata-based Emami Group. FSSAI said its trade name is "likely to mislead consumers and appears to be in contravention of

applicable FSSAI regulations". Plan B, which markets its products as "plant based vegan", has drawn the regulator's attention for creating the impression that its products are vegan — without obtaining prior approval for vegan food endorsement in its FSSAI licence.

The Healthy Factory's "Zero Maida Whole Wheat Bread" — which contains chakki fresh atta and wheat gluten - has been flagged for misleading consumers. Its "zero maida pizza base" product faces similar scrutiny, with FSSAI noting the claim appears to violate applicable regulations.

Free trade pacts to boost furniture exports, domestic manufacturing: Industry

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Exports and domestic manufacturing of India's furniture sector will witness a major boost from the number of free trade agreements (FTAs) finalised by India in recent years, industry experts say.

They said the duty concessions under these trade agreements would not only provide domestic players with preferential access to overseas markets but also encourage capacity expansion and fresh investments in India.

India has implemented FTAs with Mauritius, the UAE, Australia, the EFTA bloc, and Oman. It has signed such pacts with New Zealand and

the UK, and announced the conclusion of negotiations with the European Union.

The country is also negotiating similar trade pacts with a number of other countries, including Israel, Canada, Peru, Chile, Gulf Cooperation Council (Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar and Saudi Arabia), and Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU - Armenia, Belarus, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Russia).

"These agreements will help us provide huge export opportunities. We have already started our exports," Gujarat-based Nipponply Industries Managing Director Ketan Thakkar said.

He said that Indian products from the furniture sector

meets global standards, and there is a good demand in the international markets.

"We can do a lot of import substitution in this segment. India imports a lot of high-end office and home furnish-

ing products. We can make it all that. Our products are 100 per cent non-toxic," Thakkar said.

Nipponply Industries Project Head Aastha Thakkar said they are getting good

enquiries for their dining and office tables and chairs, such as round dining table, conference table, and monolithic buffet table.

"These items come with flame-retardant surface systems and scratch and stain-resistant surfaces," she said.

Nipponply Industries has launched AURA, a range of premium home and office organisation products designed to help users manage storage and workspace needs, with Director Smit Thakkar saying the products are made from the company's patented Nipponglint wood veneer technology for enhanced durability and aesthetics.

Indian Institute of Foreign Trade (IIFT) Vice-Chancellor Rakesh Mohan Joshi said FTAs have opened immense export opportunities for the Indian furniture sector.

"Industry should grab this opportunity," Joshi said.

Sharing similar views, Bharat Cluster Ventures Private Limited (BCVPL) Founder Amiet R Barot said the company is exporting to Europe and the US and exploring opportunities in other markets.

He said that BCVPL is developing Maharashtra Global Furniture City (MAHA-GFC) - an integrated ecosystem for the furniture fraternity focused on manufacturing, trade, exports, and logistics.

Tata Trusts to hike philanthropic spending to ₹2,000 cr this fiscal, CEO hits back at chaos narrative

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

Tata Trusts will increase its philanthropic spending to about ₹2,000 crore in the current fiscal, according to its CEO Siddharth Sharma, who hit back at media focussing only on 'chaos' in the congregation of charities that control Tata Sons, the holding company of the over USD 180 billion Tata Group.

Seeking to put "the record straight about the core activity of the Tata Trusts, for which we exist- philanthropy", in a post on LinkedIn, Sharma bemoaned the media amplifying "certain narratives unfortu-

nately, at times, without verification & analysis- that happens", terming it "both the reality and the tragedy of our times".

Recollecting how the Tata Trusts came into existence and its purpose, he wrote, "As the majority shareholders in Tata Sons, we deploy, year after year, the dividends that we receive, into philanthropic causes that uplift those at society's margins and help build a nation. This predates, by 122 years, the CSR mandate that was introduced in 2014 for Indian business.

Sharma further said, "For FY 25-26 alone, the philanthropic spending of the

Tata Trusts was ₹1,600 crores approx., slated to go up to ₹2,000 crores in the current fiscal."

This scale of spending, on a year on year basis, he said, "has enabled us to provide quality, yet affordable cancer care, to citizens of Assam, Maharashtra, Jharkhand, Andhra Pradesh and UP."

Sharma further said Tata Trusts is finalising a collaboration with a reputed educational institution to set up a world class university for undergraduate studies, while it is also contributing to setting up a state of the art multi-speciality hospital in Central India, among other

projects it is undertaking.

His post was in response to "someone offering to help me address the 'chaos' at the Tata Trusts".

Sharma's post comes amid simmering tension among trustees of the congregation of philanthropic bodies under the Tata Trust umbrella, which controls 66 per cent of Tata Sons, a situation that has continued since last year and now requires the intervention of Home Minister Amit Shah and Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman.

Notably, the matter of public listing of Tata Sons has divided opinion among the trustees, with Tata Trusts

Chairman Mohan Tata against it while Vice-Chairman Venu Srinivasan and another trustee, former defence secretary Vijay Singh publicly supporting it.

One of the trusts, Sir Ratan Tata Trust, is also facing an inquiry into alleged violation of norms related to composition of the board of trustees initiated by the Maharashtra State Charity Commissioner.

Sharma, however, in his post asserted that "Tata Trusts are continuing to do what they do best- serving those at the margins of society. No hype, no publicity; only solid, hard work. Everything else is noise."

PROSPECT



Assam CM Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma visited key locations across Guwahati on Sunday to review infrastructure, public facilities and ongoing development works



Lieutenant General V. M. Bhuwana Krishnan, General Officer Commanding-in-Chief of the Eastern Command of the Indian Army, called on Meghalaya CM Conrad Sangma

RGCIRC hosts Continuing Medical Education programme



Rajiv Gandhi Cancer Institute & Research Centre (RGCIRC), Rohini, hosted a Continuing Medical Education (CME) programme titled "Breaking Barriers in Women's Cancer: From Prevention to Survivorship" at Indraprastha Hall. The event brought together gynaecologists, oncologists, and healthcare professionals to discuss the latest approaches in prevention, early detection, diagnosis, treatment, and survivorship care for breast, cervical, endometrial, and ovarian cancers. Dr Sudhir Rawal, medical director, RGCIRC, welcomed participants and highlighted the importance of multidisciplinary collaboration. Dr DS Gangwar, CEO, RGCIRC, stressed the critical role of primary care physicians and gynaecologists in the entire cancer care continuum. Sessions were conducted by Dr Renuka Gupta, Dr Garima Daga, Dr Vandana Jain, Dr Vishvak Chanthar, and Dr Indu Aggarwal. The CME promoted integrated clinical practices, stronger referral pathways between gynaecologists and oncologists, and improved survivorship support. (PNS)

12 years of Jan Kalyan: The legacy of India's longest serving elected Prime Minister



DR. ASEERVATHAM ACHARY

10th June 2026 was not just another date in India's political calendar. It marked the successful completion of 12 years of the Narendra Modi Government and a historic milestone for Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who has become India's longest-serving elected Prime Minister. Yet, the significance of these 12 years goes far beyond electoral success. They tell the story of a nation that has steadily moved from aspiration to achievement, from entitlement to empowerment, and from incremental change to transformative progress.

When Narendra Modi took office in May 2014, India was a country with immense potential but also many persistent challenges. Millions of families lacked basic amenities. Women spent hours collecting firewood and fetching water. Poor households often had no bank account, no toilet, no health insurance, and no permanent roof over their heads. Farmers struggled with uncertainty, youth searched for opportunities, and welfare benefits

frequently failed to reach intended beneficiaries.

Today, the story is remarkably different. Across villages, towns, and cities, the signs of change are visible. A poor family that once lived in a kutcha house now owns a pucca house. A woman who cooked in a smoke-filled kitchen now has an LPG connection. A farmer receives financial assistance directly into his bank account. A street vendor has access to institutional credit. A young entrepreneur can launch a startup with government support. A poor patient can receive quality treatment without fearing financial ruin. These changes are not isolated success stories. They are part of a larger transformation that has touched millions of lives across every corner of India.

From VIP Culture to People's Participation

One of the most visible changes of the last 12 years has been the transformation in India's political culture. For decades, politics often appeared distant from ordinary citizens. Power was concentrated in government offices and elite circles, while common people frequently felt disconnected from governance.

Prime Minister Modi sought to change this relationship. The removal of red beacon vehicles became a symbol of a larger message that governance should be citizen-centric rather than privi-



The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

lege-centric. The focus shifted from VIP culture to public participation. Programmes like Mann Ki Baat, direct interaction with beneficiaries, digital governance platforms, and citizen-driven campaigns have strengthened the connection between government and people.

Fighting Poverty at an Unprecedented Scale

Perhaps no achievement better reflects the transformation of the last 12 years than the progress made in reducing poverty and improving living standards. According to official estimates, more than 25 crore Indians have moved out of multidimensional poverty. This is one of the largest

poverty reduction efforts witnessed anywhere in the world. More than 81 crore citizens today receive free food grains under the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana. During the Covid pandemic, this programme became a lifeline for millions of families and ensured food security during one of the most challenging periods in modern history.

More than 4 crore poor families have received pucca houses under the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana. For many beneficiaries, owning a permanent house was a dream that had remained unfulfilled for generations. Today, that dream stands fulfilled. The transformation is visible in every State.

Financial Inclusion for Every Citizen

A decade ago, millions of Indians had never entered a bank. Welfare

benefits often failed to reach intended beneficiaries due to leakages and middlemen. The launch of Jan Dhan Yojana changed that reality forever. Today, more than 58 crore Jan Dhan accounts have been opened, making it one of the largest financial inclusion programmes in the world.

The JAM — Trinity of Jan Dhan, Aadhaar, and Mobile has revolutionized governance. Direct Benefit Transfers now ensure that assistance reaches beneficiaries directly and transparently.

Crores of rupees that once leaked through inefficiencies are now reaching those who need them most. For millions of poor families, financial inclusion has meant more than access to banking. It has meant dignity, security, and opportunity.

Dignity and Empowerment for Women

The story of India's development over the last 12 years cannot be told without acknowledging the central role played by women. For generations, rural women spent hours collecting firewood and cooking in smoke-filled kitchens. Nearly 11 crore LPG connections under Ujjwala Yojana have transformed their daily lives now.

The writer is National Coordinator, Digital Library, Library & Documentation, BJP

Assam's K Niraj Chandra Singha commissioned into Indian Air Force

TONY DAS
Guwahati

Flying Officer K Niraj Chandra Singha from Assam has turned his childhood dream of serving the nation into reality by being commissioned into the Indian Air Force in the Meteorology Branch during the Combined Graduation Parade held at the Air Force Academy, Dundigal, on June 13, 2026.

Born and raised in Assam, Flying Officer Singha nurtured the aspiration of wearing the uniform and serving the country from a very young age. His journey stands as a testament to determination, discipline and unwavering self-belief.

An alumnus of Sainik School Goalpara, Flying Officer Singha credits the



institution for shaping his character and instilling in him the values of discipline, resilience, leadership and patriotism. Inspired by the achievements of senior cadets and alumni who went on to serve the nation in various capacities, he developed a strong resolve to join the Armed Forces.

Believing that success is achieved through persever-

ance and hard work, he consistently worked towards his goal. To broaden his horizons and strengthen his professional capabilities, he pursued a B.Tech degree while simultaneously mentoring young aspirants who shared similar dreams of serving the nation.

Despite facing numerous challenges and moments of uncertainty, Flying Officer Singha remained steadfast in his pursuit. Through patience, perseverance and dedication, he overcame every obstacle, emerging stronger with each setback.

His efforts culminated in his recommendation for the Indian Air Force's Meteorology Branch, marking the successful realisation of years of hard work, sacrifice and commitment.

CM Himanta flags off GI-tagged Tezpur litchis to Singapore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Guwahati

In an important step towards increasing the footprints of Assam's rich horticultural produce in international markets, Chief Minister Dr Himanta Biswa Sarma flagged off the export of a consignment of Geographical Indication (GI)-tagged litchis from Tezpur at the Lokpriya Gopinath Bordoloi International Airport.

The export of 500 kilograms of the renowned "Piyaji" variety of litchi to Singapore marks the beginning of a new chapter for Assam's farming community. Following the recent successful export of Assam's GI-tagged litchis to Dubai, the opening of the Singapore



market reflects the growing international demand for the State's premium agricultural produce.

The achievement is also a result of the State Government's sustained efforts to strengthen market linkages, value chains and export infrastructure.

Speaking to the media, the Chief Minister said that the Tezpur litchis have succeeded in securing a place in

international markets over the past few years. He noted that a few days ago, 2,000 kilograms of litchis were exported to Dubai through the Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority (APEDA).

The 500-kilogram consignment flagged off will be transported to Singapore by a Druk Air flight operating from Bhutan via Guwahati.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (13.6.26)

6	7	2	8	1	4	9	3	5
8	9	1	6	3	5	7	4	2
3	5	4	9	7	2	8	1	6
2	1	5	3	4	7	6	8	9
7	8	3	1	6	9	2	5	4
4	6	9	5	2	8	3	7	1
5	2	6	7	8	1	4	9	3
9	3	8	4	5	6	1	2	7
1	4	7	2	9	3	5	6	8

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
MONDAY | JUNE 15, 2026

ACROSS

1 Songs arranged by Carlos (6)
7 Liked the ultimate success of a show jumper? (8)
8 Rather than imprisonment, it's great! (4)
10 Forced to employ a chauffeur? (6)
11 Source of timber for building forts out East (6)
14 Leased for some little time (3)
16 Writer of a clever news piece? (5)
17 Growing source of a bit of a smell, possibly? (4)
19 What the fiddler did even before being applauded! (5)
21 As a broadcaster, maybe, could be

DOWN

1 Is able to get led astray by a light (6)
2 A duck subsists on fruit, it seems (6)
3 Interviewed for observation? (4)
4 One Channel port somewhere in Hants
5 It grows underground at mid-April (5)
6 Dish only half up - and tardily! (5)
8 As entertainment, it could be somewhat flimsy (4)
9 Bit of bone trouble possibly catching (3)
12 About 500 are leftist (3)
13 Difficulties getting a horse aboard ship? (5)
15 If you can't spell too well, don't throw it in! (5)

16, Ta-me-D
18, Cable
19, Creator
21, Hillary
22, Figure
23, Reggae
25, P-lane
26, Hop-e
28, Rep

15, Sabot-age
16, Ta-me-D
18, Cable
19, Creator
21, Hillary
22, Figure
23, Reggae
25, P-lane
26, Hop-e
28, Rep

1, CL-out
6, Sc-a-MP
9, Nucle-ar
10, Chain
11, Mo-T-or
12, Tr-O-op
13, Ar-men-ia
15, Set
17, Lea-d
18, Can-Ada

19, Clear
20, Cherry
22, Fore
24, Kid
25, Pila-Red
26, Halle
27, Tar-ot
28, Rud-g-e
29, Pointer
30, Ty-L-er
31, Peter

Protein supplements can be risky: Dr Sahni

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The growing craze for gyms and fitness is attracting young people toward supplements at a rapid pace. However, experts warn that using certain supplements without proper research and verification can pose serious health risks.

According to Dr Kartik Sahni, Founder and Gastroenterologist at Sahni Gastro & Liver Care, Shakti Nagar, not every protein supplement available in the market is safe. Some products may contain substances that are not even disclosed on their labels. These may



include anabolic steroids, heavy metals, and other hepatotoxic chemicals that can cause severe liver damage.

Dr Sahni stated that if a person experiences symptoms such as fatigue, loss of appetite, acidity, yellowing of the eyes, or any other

unusual signs after taking supplements, they should immediately stop using the product and consult a medical specialist.

One such case involved a 28-year-old fitness enthusiast who started consuming a protein supplement on the recommendation of his gym trainer. Initially, he noticed rapid muscle growth and improved performance. However, within a few weeks, he began experiencing persistent fatigue, reduced appetite, acidity, and yellowing of the eyes.

Medical tests revealed significantly elevated liver enzyme levels. Further investigations found that the sup-

plement he was consuming contained undisclosed anabolic steroids and liver-damaging chemicals. As a result, he developed chronic liver damage.

Dr Sahni advised consumers to purchase supplements only from trusted and certified brands, verify third-party testing certifications, and avoid compromising their health in pursuit of rapid body transformation.

He emphasised that the cost of fast transformation is often paid by the body's vital organs.

"Muscles can be rebuilt, but liver damage may not always be completely reversible," Dr Sahni said.

Indian Army, Bharti Airtel sign MoU to expand mobile connectivity in remote areas of Arunachal

TONY DAS
Itanagar

In a significant step towards nation-building through military-civil integration, the Indian Army and Bharti Airtel Pvt. Ltd have signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to expand communication infrastructure and establish mobile connectivity in remote areas of the Kameng district, Arunachal Pradesh.

The initiative aims to bring reliable mobile connectivity to communities that have remained disconnected for over a decade, addressing a critical developmental need in one of the country's strategically important frontier regions. By bridging the digital divide, the project will facilitate greater access to government services, digital education, health-



care, financial inclusion, and communication facilities, thereby improving the quality of life for local residents.

Enhanced connectivity is also expected to promote tourism and create new opportunities for economic growth and socio-economic development across the region. Improved communication infrastructure will strengthen the integration of

remote border communities with the national mainstream and contribute to the Government's vision of inclusive development.

From a security perspective, the upgraded network infrastructure will support the operational effectiveness of Indian Army troops deployed in forward areas by enabling improved communication capabilities and enhancing logistical coordi-

nation. The initiative reflects the synergy between civil and military stakeholders in advancing both developmental and strategic objectives.

The partnership underscores a shared commitment to strengthening border areas through sustainable infrastructure development and aligns with the national vision of Viksit Bharat @ 2047.

BRIEFLY

Unbeaten Chambal Ghariyals clinch maiden MPLT20 title



Chambal Ghariyals defeated Gwalior Shernis by two runs in a last-ball thriller to win their maiden Madhya Pradesh League (MPL) T20 Scindia Cup 2026 here. Batting first, Chambal Ghariyals posted a competitive 146 for 4 in their 20 overs, thanks largely to another impressive half-century from in-form opener Kanishka Thakur. Thakur and Jincy George gave the innings a solid start, adding 51 runs for the opening wicket in 7.1 overs before George was dismissed for 15 off 19 balls. Thakur then combined with Rahila Firdous for another useful 33-run partnership that kept the momentum going. Thakur continued her fine run in the tournament with a fluent 50 off 37 deliveries before departing. Firdous anchored the middle overs with a run-a-ball 29, while Vaishnavi Singh provided the finishing touches with an unbeaten 26 off 20 deliveries to push the Ghariyals to a challenging total. In reply, Gwalior Shernis suffered an early setback when Aashna Patidar was dismissed for 10 off 16 balls. However, captain Nuzhat Parween and Ishana Swami steadied the chase with a crucial 64-run partnership. The breakthrough came when Dhani Buchade struck at the right time, dismissing Ishana for 29 off 22 after she miscued a shot and was caught. Soumya Tiwari fell soon after for 4 off 5 balls, leaving the Shernis at 108 for 3 after 16 overs.

(PTI)

Neeraj Chopra named in CWG squad subject to qualification



Two-time Olympic medalist javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra was on Sunday named in India's athletics squad for the Commonwealth Games, subject to achieving the Athletics Federation of India's (AFI) qualifying standard in upcoming competitions. The 32-member squad, finalised after the federation's final selection committee meeting, also includes Gurindervir Singh (100m), Animesh Kujur (200m), Gulveer Singh (5,000m and 10,000m), Tejaswin Shankar (decathlon and high jump), Parul Chaudhary (3000m steeplechase) and racewalker Priyanka. The Commonwealth Games are scheduled to be held Glasgow, Scotland from July 23 to August 2. Neeraj to return to action in next 10 days: Chopra, who has not competed since the 2025 World Championships in Tokyo, has been recovering from a back injury and is yet to begin his season. The former world champion is, however, expected to return to competition within the next 10 days and has requested the AFI to consider his performances in the upcoming events for Commonwealth Games qualification. "Neeraj has recovered from his back injury. He is now training fit and is getting ready to compete probably in the next 10 days or so," AFI selection committee chairman Adille Sumariwalla said in a virtual press conference.

Scotland marks 1-0 victory over Haiti in Group C

KYLE HIGHTOWER
■ Foxborough (Massachusetts)

Coach Steve Clarke made it clear he didn't enjoy his first two experiences leading Scotland during lackluster showings in the European Championship.

So far the sport's biggest stage has brought him — and the Scots — a lot more luck.

John McGinn deflected a shot off an opposing defender and past goalkeeper Johnny Placide in the 28th minute, and Scotland defeated Haiti 1-0 in Group C of the World Cup on Saturday.

"When it went into the back of the net, you could feel the Scotland fans," McGinn said.

Scotland, making its first



appearance in the tournament since 1998, earned its first World Cup victory since 1990, when it beat Sweden 2-1. "We came here to get three points. We did and now we move on," Scotland midfielder Lewis Ferguson

Australia spoils Turkey's return to World Cup

ANNE M PETERSON
■ Vancouver (Canada)

Nestory Irankunda and Connor Metcalfe scored and Australia spoiled Turkey's return to the World Cup for the first time in 24 years with a 2-0 victory on Saturday night. Goalkeeper Patrick Beach made eight saves for the Socceroos in their group opener as FIFA President Gianni Infantino looked on. Australia was playing in its sixth straight World Cup and seventh overall.

Turkey reached the semifinals of the 2002 World Cup but then missed five straight tournaments before qualifying this year by beating Kosovo in a playoff.

Irankunda broke through for the Socceroos in the 27th minute with a low shot while pursued by three defenders. It came less than a minute after the first-half hydration break. Irankunda celebrated by punching the corner flag in a tribute to Australian soccer legend Tim Cahill. The 20-year-old who plays for Watford is the Socceroo's youngest-ever goal scorer at a World Cup.

Minutes later Beach stopped Abdulkерim Bardakci's blast from distance. Beach started in goal for the Socceroos rather than experienced counterpart Matthew Ryan in a surprise decision from coach Tony Popovic. Irankunda said the



Socceroos took issue with comments Turkey captain Hakan Calhanoglu made a day before the match, proclaiming that his side had "more qualities and a more talented team."

"Yeah, it was extra motiva-

tion," Irankunda said. "Obviously we don't like people to talk bad about us because we're a great team. People underestimate us."

Kenan Yildiz, a 21-year-old who plays for Juventus, was not in the starting lineup but

Depay, Verbruggen ready for Netherlands' FIFA World Cup opener against Japan

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Arlington

The Netherlands will have goalkeeper Bart Verbruggen and top scorer Memphis Depay both ready to play in the team's World Cup opener.

Coach Ronald Koeman said Saturday, on the eve of the Group F game against Japan, that his entire team is fit. That includes Verbruggen and Depay, though the coach wasn't ready to reveal his starting lineup.

The status of Verbruggen was in question after he hurt his hip in a collision during a tune-up match with Uzbekistan on Monday, and



then was held out of training Wednesday. But Koeman said the keeper returned to full practice Friday and Saturday.

Depay, the Netherlands' all-time leading scorer with 55 goals, dealt with a thigh injury for several weeks before playing for Brazilian

club Corinthians on May 24. That was only three days before the 26-man Netherlands roster for the World Cup was set.

Koeman said Depay has looked good since the start of the team's tournament preparations.

Indian women eye positive start against USA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Auckland

With goals firmly set on returning to the elite FIH Pro League next season, the Indian women's hockey team is determined to make a positive start to its campaign in the FIH Nations Cup against a tricky USA here on Monday. The India women's team was relegated from the elite FIH Pro League to the second-tier Women's FIH Hockey Nations Cup, following its last-place finish in the 2024-25 season, where it managed only 10 points from 16 matches.

The winner of the eight-nation FIH Nations Cup will be promoted to the Pro League next year.

Captained by Salima Tete, India will open their Pool A

campaign against the United States before facing Japan on June 16 and Uruguay on June 18. Pool B includes hosts New Zealand, Chile, Korea and France.

India will look to make a strong start in the pool stage and build momentum heading into the knockout rounds, scheduled to take place on June 20 and 21.

Going by world rankings, India will head into the match as favourites. India are placed ninth in the FIH rankings as against USA's 12th place.

The tournament also offers valuable international exposure against quality opposition as the Indian team continues its preparations for major events this year, including the 2026 FIH Hockey World Cup and the



Asian Games. Notably, India head into the tournament on the back of a competitive four-match tour of Australia, where they showcased impressive character against one of the world's strongest teams on their home turf.

After suffering a narrow defeat in the opening

encounter, the Indian side bounced back in emphatic fashion to register victories in the next two matches before Australia won the final game, resulting in the friendly series ending in a 2-2 draw. The tour offered several encouraging signs for the Indian camp, with the team demonstrating

resilience under pressure, tactical discipline across all phases of play and a potent attacking threat.

The performances reinforced the progress made by the squad in recent months and provided valuable momentum heading into the FIH Nations Cup, the first major assignment of an important international season away from home.

Speaking ahead of the tournament, the Indian women team's chief coach Sjoerd Marijne expressed confidence in the squad's preparation and mindset.

"The Australia tour was an excellent preparation for us. We were pleased with the way the players responded to challenges, adapted to different situations and competed against a top-quality side.



He played a lot, we trust him a lot and I think in order to have a good World Cup, we need Manuel in top performance and I think he can bring that."

There were questions about his health after he injured his left calf during Bayern's last Bundesliga

Nagelsmann: Neuer fit as Germany opens World Cup vs Curacao

KRISTIE RIEKEN
■ Houston (US)

Goalkeeper Manuel Neuer has fully recovered from a calf injury he sustained last month and is ready to go for Germany's World Cup opener against Curacao on Sunday. The 40-year-old enters the World Cup having not played for Germany in almost two years after coach Julian Nagelsmann lured him out of international retirement.

"(He's) definitely fit enough to start the game and he got better and better," Nagelsmann said Saturday night. "He didn't really have the rhythm, but now he found the rhythm.

game of the season in late May and missed the German Cup final against Stuttgart for what was called "muscular problems in his left calf."

The Bayern Munich captain is the only remaining member of the World Cup-winning team from 2014 on the Germany squad. This will be his fifth World Cup, which will tie the German record held by Lothar Matthaus. His return to the national team has been a boost to younger members of the squad who have leaned on him during preparations as Germany tries to bounce back after two successive World Cup group-stage exits.

Khouchi's header in stoppage time earns Qatar draw with Switzerland

JANIE MCCAULEY
■ Santa Clara (US)

Qatar might be able to finally move forward from its forgettable home World Cup four years ago, scoring a stoppage-time goal to earn a shocking 1-1 draw with Group B favourite Switzerland on Saturday.

And oh, what a miss by the mighty Swiss.

One TV headline back home at French language public broadcaster RTS blared: "QATARSTROPHE."

Boualem Khouchi scored the equalising goal on a header in the fourth minute of injury time to give Qatar its first-ever point at the



World Cup in front of 67,966 spectators at Levi's Stadium. "Every draw feels like a loss," Switzerland midfielder Granit Khaka said. "We're looking at ourselves. This performance was not good enough today to win."

Several of the Qatari players fell to the ground in celebration of the late goal

the match and outshot the Socceroos 30-9, but couldn't manage to score.

"I respect Australia very much. I was expecting that they would play in this way," said Turkey coach Vincenzo Montella, who took the team to the quarterfinals of the European championships in 2024. "This is football. As for the critics, nobody has underestimated Australia, actually."

It is the third World Cup appearance for the Turks, who reached the tournament for the first time in 1954.

The teams are in Group D with the United States and Paraguay. The Americans downed Paraguay 4-1 in their group opener on Friday in Los Angeles.

(AP)

Portugal embraces World Cup expectations, carries Jota's memory

ALANIS THAMES
■ Palm Beach

Portugal is very aware of the enormous expectations it faces in the World Cup.

The squad featuring star forward Cristiano Ronaldo is among the favorites to win the expanded 48-team tournament and hoist its first World Cup trophy, but players are not looking ahead to that point yet.

"We have not talked about putting the high pressure on our team," midfielder Vitorinha said through a translator Saturday before Portugal's first training session in the United States.



"All competitions are won by focusing on the present moment and not worrying about future outcomes."

"What we can do is think game by game. ... We would love to win, and if we go through the group stage, we will go one game at a time."

Portugal begins group

play against Congo on June 17 in Houston.

Vitorinha said the team believes it has the talent to go far in the tournament, and each player will compete with a heartfelt reminder. Portugal's Prime Minister recently met with the team and gifted each player a bracelet bearing their name as well as the name of the late Liverpool forward Diogo Jota, who was killed in a car crash in Spain last July.

Jota, who was a regular on Portugal's squad, was also included this year as an honorary team member by coach Roberto Martinez.

After 53 years, the New York Knicks are NBA champions



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ San Antonio (US)

Knowing New York had waited 53 years to see the Knicks hoist the NBA championship trophy, owner James Dolan didn't even want to be handed the 30-pound gold-plated prize.

He grabbed it and lifted it skyward with a yell. "I want to say something to New York," Dolan shouted. "Hey New York! I'm sorry it took so long! But here we are, and hopefully it won't take that long again!" The New York Knicks are champions of the NBA for the first time since 1973, beating the San Antonio Spurs in five games for this title.

The clincher came Saturday night in a 94-90 victory, the Knicks' fourth comeback win of the series. Some will say it's the first "major" professional sports championship for New York in more than 14 years; that would be true when counting only Major League Baseball, the NFL and the NHL and the NBA, though it would be wrong to ignore the New York Liberty's run to the 2024 WNBA title and New York City FC winning the MLS Cup in 2021.

Vinicius Junior scores in Brazil's opening draw with Morocco

STEPHEN WHYNO
■ East Rutherford (US)

When Brazil found itself trailing Morocco in each team's World Cup opener and the crowd full of yellow-clad Selecao fans went from nervously quiet to stunned silent on Saturday night, Vinicius Junior was there to bring the life back with a highlight-reel moment.

The soon-to-be 26-year-old left winger passed the ball to Bruno Guimaraes to draw in three defenders and then did the rest himself. Vinicius deked around Neil El Aynaoui and fired a right-footed shot through Morocco's defense and into the far corner of the net past goalkeeper Yassine Bounou. "We had to adapt as

fast as possible because they scored on us too early, and it completely changed our way of play," Vinicius said through an interpreter. "After they scored a goal against us, we were able to react very quickly and we scored a goal." The crowd-pleasing goal for more than 75,000 in attendance provided enough offense to earn Brazil a 1-1 draw in the only group stage match of the tournament between teams in the top 10 of the FIFA world rankings. Coach Carlo Ancelotti caught some criticism for not playing teenager Endrick, and adjustments are coming, but Vinicius was a difference-maker at the start of his second World Cup. "He did well," Ancelotti said. "He was



dangerous, and I think he has everything in his power to have a good World Cup."

The player nicknamed Vini thinks he has better to show in the tournament. Coming off scoring 16 goals in 36 games with Real Madrid, he

had the ball on several occasions against Morocco in position to create scoring chances. "I believe I can improve a lot," Vinicius said. "I was able to score the goal, but I'm not yet at 100 percent of my technical skill. I can

improve on that and help Brazil on the attacking."

The goal by Vinicius was his first in a head-to-head matchup against Achraf Hakimi, internationally or in club play with Real Madrid. Hakimi is Morocco's captain and has played for Paris Saint-Germain since 2021.

Morocco coach Mohamed Ouahbi called it a team defensive blunder. "Vinicius, obviously he's a great player," Ouahbi said through an interpreter. "But we didn't have enough players in the zone at the time. We had lost the ball suddenly, and they counter-attacked, so it was much harder to defend. And when you're up against Vinicius, well, it's hard to defend together."

(AP)

Smriti, Deepti shine in India's 64-run victory over Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Birmingham

The peerless Deepti Sharma strangulated an out of sync Pakistan with a five-wicket haul after Smriti Mandhana's delectable half-century as India thrashed Pakistan by 64 runs to make a winning start to their Women's T20 World Cup campaign here on Sunday.

Courtsey Mandhana's classy 44-ball-68 and Richa Ghosh's muscular 34 off 17 balls, India managed a winning score of 170 for 6.

Save Muneeba Ali's 35-ball-41, there was no sting in Pakistan batting as they folded for a meagre 106 in 17 overs. Having played her part in a priceless 45-run

stand with Ghosh, Deepti was in her element with the ball, picking up a career-best 5 for 10 in 4 overs while left-arm spinner Shree Charani grabbed 3 for 21. Shafali Verma's happy knack of picking wickets also helped India. En route her five-wicket haul, Deepti also became the highest wicket-taker in the history of Women's T20 Internationals.

With the third game being played on the same Edgbaston track, India got the advantage of bowling second as there was some turn on offer and the odd ball gripped, not allowing the batters to hit through the line. Deepti was literally unplayable on this pitch. The most telling contribu-



India's Deepti Sharma attempts to run out Pakistan's Natalia Parvaiz during the ICC Women's T20 World Cup, Group 1 cricket match between India and Pakistan in Birmingham, England, Sunday

PTI

tion during Indian fielding also came from Deepti, whose direct throw ended left-handed keeper-batter Muneeba's flashy innings.

Earlier, Mandhana's batting was grace personified as her regal knock along with Ghosh's cameo took India to a winning total. Ghosh provided the final flourish as left-arm seamer Tasmia Rubab went for 23 runs in the penultimate over which eventually broke Pakistan's backbone. Mandhana's elegance was on full display at Edgbaston as she caressed the ball to boundary with sheer timing.

The six off left-arm seamer Rubab had class written all over it. Dancing down the track, the inside out bound-

aries off off-spinner Rameen Shamim were a work of art as she completed her half-century off just 34 balls. Her innings had nine boundaries and two sixes in it.

Shamim though finally had Mandhana when her mistimed hit was well taken by skipper Fatima Sana, who timed her slide to perfection. Mandhana had company in her seasoned skipper Harmanpreet Kaur (36 off 35 balls) as the duo added 91 runs for the third wicket after Shafali Verma (6) and Jemimah Rodrigues (1) cheap dismissals had India under pressure at 18 for 2.

The skipper and her deputy were cautious with the Powerplay ending at 30 for 2 but they didn't let go of the

opportunity to hit the boundaries. In the next seven overs, India scored 70 runs and Mandhana got a couple of reprieves where Pakistan's butter-fingered fielders let regulation chances slip by.

The left-hander was dropped off Rubab's bowling when her mistimed lofted shot was dropped by the fielder stationed at mid-off, who failed to latch on to the ball while running backwards. The other was a big hit with the fielder at wide long-on boundary who saw it go for a six as it slipped between her palms. The unlucky bowler was left-arm spinner Sadia Iqbal (2/41), easily one of their best performers along with skipper Fatima Sana (2/33).

Rana instilled discipline and a results-oriented mindset in Manu: Father

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Grief-stricken double Olympic medallist Manu Bhaker's father, Ram Kishan, remembers Jaspal Rana as a coach who brought much-needed discipline and a results-oriented approach into his daughter's life, helping make her a champion shooter.

Rana, 49, died on Thursday following a brief illness after battling cardiac complications. One of India's finest pistol shooters, Rana made a successful transition to coaching and played a pivotal role in guiding Manu to her historic twin bronze medals at the Paris Olympics. "The biggest contribution Jaspal Rana made to Manu's

shooting career was instilling discipline, focus, hard work and a result-oriented approach. He was a good coach. His training imparted to Manu was excellent. It is a huge tragedy that he left the world like this. We are extremely saddened by what has happened," Kishan told PTI on Saturday.

"No one thought he would leave like this. What he used to say to Manu was: work hard and have faith in yourself. Be confident in yourself. You have fighting spirit. You can do it. And you will do it. He was, you know, a hard taskmaster but good at heart. Hard from outside and soft from inside. He was a legendary shooter and a result-oriented coach. And a very



Jaspal Rana, the Asian Games gold medallist shooter who later guided Manu Bhaker to her historic double bronze-medal feat at the Paris Olympics as a coach, died at the age of 49 at a Delhi hospital

PTI

strict and disciplined person," said Kishan.

"I would say that Jaspal was very strict. He used to

scold constantly. And he used to get angry like a little kid. If you didn't listen to him, he would get angry. But he was

strict. And Manu preferred a strict and disciplined life."

Asked what Manu had told him since news of Rana's demise broke, Kishan said: "She is not able to talk right now. Whenever I call her, she picks up the phone and says, 'I will talk to you later, Papa.' And, you know, with a personal loss, it takes time. Let her recover fully and then she will decide what she needs and how we can help."

Recalling Rana's strict and disciplined coaching methods, he said: "Many times, Manu would be told to reach the range at 6 (am). If the range was closed and the guards had locked it, we would ask them to open it. They used to do that."

Kishan disclosed the cause

of the rift between Manu and Rana in 2021.

"Actually, two or three months before Tokyo (Olympics), Jaspal suddenly said that he will not coach Manu. There were some issues going on. Manu had qualified for two Olympic events (10m air pistol and 25m sports pistol). She wanted to compete in both. Jaspal wanted her to drop out of 25m pistol event," he recalled.

"That had a lot of (adverse) effect on Manu. Her matches (after the Tokyo Olympics) were also going very badly. She didn't know whether she should continue (shooting) or not. She was a teenager then. She wanted to become a doctor or an engineer. (PTI)



Australia thumps SA, NZ fumbles WI in T20 WC

FOSTER NIUMATA
■ Manchester

Australia won the first heavyweight clash of the Women's Twenty20 World Cup after routing South Africa for 107 in Manchester on Saturday.

Going for a seventh title in the 10th World Cup, Australia battled to put up 172-8 then won by 65 runs at Old Trafford. South Africa was runner-up in the last two tournaments and beat Australia when they previously met in the 2024 semifinals. But the Proteas now must top the other group rival India on June 21 to stay in semifinal contention. Another title favorite suffered a setback when titleholder New Zealand lost to the West Indies — in another 2024 semifinals rematch — by seven wickets on the second-to-last ball in Southampton.

Earlier in a blustery, overcast Manchester, Scotland earned its first World Cup win at Ireland's expense by a comfortable 40 runs.

Ireland, chasing a first win for 12 years, dropped its win-loss record to 0-18.

Litchfield and spinners thump South Africa: Phoebe Litchfield missed Australia's last warmup due to a quad strain but passed fit in time for their opening match. She was needed in the first over.

Georgia Voll was out for a duck in her World Cup debut and fellow opener Beth Mooney was gone in the fourth over. But Litchfield, undaunted, charged at Marizanne Kapp, pulled Shabnim Ismail for six, and scooped and swept Ayabonga Khaka to raise a 23-ball 50.

Litchfield was out next ball at 61-3 and Australia wobbled again, but Ellyse Perry and Georgia Wareham revived charge with 30s in a 58-run stand. Ismail retired after the 2023 World Cup and unretired at 37. The pacer took wicket but didn't complete her overs because of a finger injury. Ismail batted, though, when result was already settled. (AP)

India stun Korea again, Dhiraj-Kumkum win mixed team gold

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Antalya

Indian recurve archers continued their resurgence on the world stage, with Olympian Dhiraj Bommadevara and teenager Kumkum Mohod producing a fearless display to upset Olympic champions South Korea and clinch the recurve mixed team gold at the Archery World Cup Stage 3, here on Sunday.

The Indian pair defeated Kim Je-deok and Oh Ye-jin 5-1 (37-36, 37-36, 39-39) in a high-quality final, showing remarkable composure and intent against one of the most decorated teams in world archery.

Displaying maturity beyond her age, the 17-year-



old Kumkum said she focused on the process rather than the opposition.

"I believed in myself completely. I just focused on the process and didn't think

about who was standing in front of me," she said. "I think I shot better today

than I did in Shanghai. But definitely that gold medal there gave me a lot of confidence."

The victory marked India's second triumph over South Korea in as many months and underlined the growing confidence within the recurve setup in the build-up to the Asian Games in three months' time.

At the Shanghai World Cup last month, the women's trio of Deepika Kumari, Kumkum and Ankita Bhakat had stunned the record 10-time Olympic champions in the semifinals en route to gold. For Dhiraj, 24, and 17-year-old Kumkum, there was no trace of intimidation against a Korean side featuring Kim, the Tokyo Olympics mixed team gold medallist

alongside An San and a member of South Korea's Paris Olympics gold-winning men's team.

Dhiraj and Kumkum, who made her World Cup debut only this season, held their nerve throughout the contest, matching the Koreans arrow for arrow before producing the decisive shots under pressure. Paris Olympian Dhiraj, India's highest-ranked recurve archer at world No. 16, capped the victory in style by shooting a perfect 10 in the final arrow of the match. Overall the duo shot three 10s each; while Kumkum shot three 9s, Dhiraj shot two and once he shot into 8-ring, that summed up their team bonding.

Parul Chaudhary betters own record to finish second

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's Parul Chaudhary bettered her own national record in the women's 5000m event by clocking a new personal best time of 15:04.26 to finish second at the Meeting Nikaia 2026 in Nice, France.

The Indian athlete finished the race behind Ethiopia's Bereka Seniya Mohammed, who just about edged out Parul from the top spot with a meet record time of 15:03.85. Alessia Zarbo of France ended third with a season best 15:16.83.



"Parul Chaudhary clocked a sensational 15:04.26 to finish 2nd and set a new National Record at the Meeting Nikaia 2026," the Athletics Federation of India (AFI) tweeted. Saturday's effort meant Parul breached the AFI's Asian Games 2026 qualifying standard of 15:36.58s in the 5000m.

Vaibhav batted for 100 overs each day: Coach Manish Ojha

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi's breathtaking pyrotechnics in the last two editions of the IPL might have left everyone awestruck, but creating the muscle memory for his wide range took six years of gruelling work. According to his childhood coach, Manish Ojha, the young batter practiced for eight hours daily, facing 100 overs.

World cricket's most exciting batting sensation at 15 and half years has already received India call-up for the T20I tour of United Kingdom after a stupendous IPL season when he emerged as the top scorer



with 776 runs at a eye-popping strike-rate of 237 plus.

Ojha, who trained Sooryavanshi from the age of eight at his academy in Patna, spoke to PTI about the hard work put in by his ward and the sacrifices

made by his parents Sanjeev and Aarti. He also revealed how parents are now flocking to academies with kids as young as five, with an aim to turn their off-springs into 'Next Vaibhav'.

But it is easier said than done, Ojha maintained.

So once Sooryavanshi switched from tennis to hardball, how many balls would he face on an average since age 10? Ojha's answer would blow away everyone. "See, we don't count the balls, how many balls he played, but I will give you a minimum estimate, that he played more than 600 balls," Ojha told PTI during an exclusive interview. (PTI)

People naturally start looking for your successor: Graeme Swann

ANKIT SHRESTHA ■ Dharamsala

India may still have two ODIs remaining against Afghanistan, but conversations about the future are never far away when it comes to Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli.

Former England spinner Graeme Swann believes that is simply the reality facing every great player in the latter stages of their career, arguing that even the most accomplished cricketers cannot escape questions about who comes next.

With India set to travel to England in July for a three-match

ODI series following the Afghanistan assignment, Swann observed that scrutiny surrounding Rohit and Kohli is only natural as a younger generation begins to emerge. "Absolutely. I think it's inevitable with any player when you come to the latter stage of your career, the second half of your career, if you like, that people naturally start looking for your successor, no matter how well you do," Swann told PTI Videos in an exclusive interview.

"And even if you're at the top of your game, they're still looking like, who will be the next Virat?



Who will be the next Rohit when they go? That's very natural.

"And the second you have one or two low scores, everyone starts looking over your shoulder and seeing who's next in line.

"And obviously, with Sooryavanshi coming through and some of the youngsters, it puts even more onus on the guys, especially at the top of the order for India." Swann believes the coming weeks could prove significant for Rohit as India continue balancing established stars with emerging talent.

"So I think it's a huge six weeks for Rohit. But like I said, in the IPL,

he looks in great touch and he's still one of the best players going, let's face it. "So if I was an English bowler, I wouldn't really want to bowl against a Rohit Sharma who's desperate to prove a point and keep his place."

While discussions around India's veterans continue, Swann believes both Rohit and Kohli remain formidable propositions for opposition bowlers.

Asked about India's upcoming ODI assignment in England, the former off-spinner said the series would once again bring the spotlight onto two of the game's

biggest names. "Yeah, it's going to be huge. Anytime England play India, it's a massive series, especially recently. "And with all the nonsense going on in England as well, I think they'll really appreciate a bit of spotlight going on the actual cricket rather than off the field stuff." Asked which of the two veterans would attract greater attention heading into the series in light of the ODI World Cup next year in South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia, Swann pointed to Kohli's remarkable 2026 IPL campaign as the 37-year-old scored 675 runs from 16 matches. (PTI)